You Mean Something to Me

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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You Mean Something to Me

by xSapphicPrincessesx (orphan_account)

Summary

What if Adora gets beamed onto Horde Prime's ship instead of Glimmer?

How far will Glimmer go to save Adora? Will they make it up to each other?

When Catra realizes that her actions affect others, will she own up to what she did?

Separated

Adora raced out of the Crystal Castle, sprinting into the woods. She had to make sure Glimmer and Bow were safe. A cool breeze rippled through her hair as she picked up the pace. Countless trees and bushes whizzed past her. She had to get there as soon as possible. Before she reached the edge of the Fright Zone, a sickly green glow flooded her vision. What was going on? The next thing she knew, an invisible force lifted her upward. It wasn't a cruel trick of the universe, right? Within a few seconds, she found herself in a spacious hall. The entire floor was white. Where was she? Did someone capture her?

"It has been a long time, little brother," a cold voice said, drawing Adora's attention to a white-clad figure.

Adora put two and two together, despite not asking a single question. *Horde Prime.* She forced herself up and put on a brave face. The mere presence of this man filled her with dread. If she had She-Ra's power, she would protect herself. Because she had broken the sword, she couldn't do it. Swallowing a hard lump in her throat, she crossed her arms and straightened her spine. Several minutes blurred past her; Hordak screaming in pain, Horde Prime ordering the guards to send him to "reconditioning," and asking the clones to leave the hall.

Horde Prime scrutinized Adora's body language, as though attempting to pry into her mind. "So, you're the key to Etheria's power. I can sense the warrior within you, little sister." He stepped forward and placed his icy hand onto her chin.

Goosebumps formed on every inch of Adora's skin. She swatted Horde Prime's hand away, then dug her nails into her palms. "In case you're wondering, I'll never work for you. I saw what you were capable of."

"I desire peace and order," Horde Prime said. "The asset I sent to reconditioning, he is flawed and needs to be renewed. I've dug

through his memories, and according to him, you were She-Ra, the defender of Etheria. You'll be a useful asset for my army."

Adora's stomach churned at the thought of helping the warlord. Suppressing the urge to throw up, she narrowed her eyes. "There is no way I will ever help you, so forget it!"

"Are you sure you want to go back and worry about carrying an immense burden on your shoulders? You can stay in one of the guest rooms and consider my offer."

Horde Prime summoned the clones into the hall; a pair of them grabbed Adora and escorted her into a long corridor. Flashes of her life on Etheria surfaced; the night she found the Sword of Protection, the day she saved Thaymor, and everything else she could remember. Soon, all she could think about was Glimmer. She had failed to be the hero the queen deserved. What did the queen think of her now? There was no She-Ra to protect Etheria right now.

The two clones shoved Adora into a cell. She would rather not be here. Sighing, she searched every inch of the cell for a way out. However, there were no vents and no loose walls. No hidden doors, either. She charged at the green force field; it didn't budge. A kick, then a punch. Same result. Muttering to herself, she plopped onto the cot. Would her friends come to the rescue? Or would they think that she abandoned them? The latter would be more likely. Why else would people expect her to be this perfect hero who never let things go wrong?

Glimmer and Bow made their way to the Crystal Castle. Earlier, he had helped her leave the Fright Zone. And now, they were searching for Adora. There were a lot of things she wanted to say to her, including a much-needed apology. As they entered the temple, she detected something on the floor; fragments of the Sword of Protection. Where did the blonde go? Scrutinizing the area, she gathered the shards. A memory of Adora reclining on a surface flashed into her mind. Maybe it was happening the second

time. She led Bow into a dark chamber, where they once found Adora unconscious after the hero ran off.

"Adora?" Glimmer called out.

No one answered. Adora would have told them where she was going. Perhaps she was out there on her own again. Unless-

"You saw those ships in the sky, didn't you?" Glimmer asked as she glanced at Bow.

"Yes. Why?" Bow replied.

"Something may have happened to Adora."

"She probably went to Bright Moon."

"We don't know where she is."

They left the temple. Glimmer gazed at the dark sky, wondering if one of those ships had abducted Adora. Etheria was in much more danger than ever, and whoever took Adora could be holding her hostage. Adora had no way of defending herself against a formidable foe. Hoofsteps approached, interrupting Glimmer's thoughts.

"Swift Wind, can you sense her?" Glimmer asked.

"I tried," Swift Wind replied, frowning. "And I couldn't."

Catra strode past the rubble, making her way toward the chair that Hordak once sat on. Well, she had also occupied the chair not too long ago, right before she took the crystal out of Hordak's chest. Climbing the ladder to the top had been her goal for a while. But at what cost? Silence blanketed the headquarters as she walked to Scorpia's old room. Leaning against the bed frame, she scrutinized the folded clothes. The pillows and blanket remained untouched ever since her former friend's departure. She swore there was a layer of dust on every surface. Tail swishing to

one side, she grabbed a picture frame. In the picture, she was sitting with Entrapta and Scorpia. She had sent the former to Beast Island, and pushed the latter away.

You're a bad friend.

Catra's ears twitched. Why did those words still haunt her? Placing the frame back onto the nightstand, she stepped into the hallway. Was there anything left for her in this garbage dump? Anything but memories of her time here? Broken friendships, promises, and thwarted missions? She walked outside, then continued to the boundary of the Fright Zone.

You made your choice. Now live with it!

A half-hour passed as Catra wandered into the Whispering Woods. What was the point of returning to the place she grew up in? She couldn't lead a broken army. And Hordak was with Horde Prime now. She held no desire to surrender to the Rebellion, let alone the Princess Alliance. Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio were nowhere to be found. Double Trouble wasn't loyal. And Scorpia defected. Long before all of that, Adora ran off to play the hero. What did Catra gain the Force Captain badge for? She thought she wanted the power that came with the title. However, it wasn't as satisfying as she hoped it would be.

But Catra had been at someone else's mercy her entire life, and she had grown up in Adora's shadow. According to the woman who raised them, Adora was special. While Adora was the golden child, everyone else considered Catra second best. No matter how hard she worked, no one gave her credit for the effort she put in. As a path out of the woods came into view, she peeked at the sky. Tiny pinpricks of light twinkled in the inky blackness.

Adora had no idea how long she had been stuck on the Velvet Glove, though she suspected that she was here for a few days. Loneliness seeped into her heart as she paced back and forth. The force field disappeared, revealing a clone. If those guards ever

said something, they'd usually say "little sister," "Horde Prime knows all, sees all," or whatever else they would rehash. She swore they all had the same personality. The clone placed a tray of food onto the table and left. Once again, the barrier kept her in. She had tracked the guards' schedule, hoping to find an opening. Maybe if she tricked one of them, she would flee.

Despite being referred to as a "guest," Adora knew she was a prisoner. They locked her up! And they were keeping a close eye on her. She grabbed the tray and sat on the cot, poking at the food with a fork. Her stomach grumbled, yet she didn't have the heart to eat. Her captors gave her the same thing each time; there was no variety.

Adora began dwelling on her memories of the past few months. They brimmed with strife and hurt. All she wanted to do was take care of Glimmer, even if it seemed as though she had gone too far. There were times when Glimmer complained about being treated like a child who couldn't make independent decisions. And as things got heated between them, the queen blamed her for Angella's sacrifice in the portal. And to top it all off, Glimmer listened to Shadow Weaver. What happened to the Glimmer who saved Adora from being mind-wiped? Would things ever get back to the way they were? Or was it too late? She missed how close they were.

How many times in the past had Adora turned to Glimmer for comfort after a nightmare? And how many times had she debated knocking on Glimmer's bedroom door during their rift? She couldn't deny how alone she felt in here. As if the outside world had forgotten about her. Tears streamed down her cheeks as she slowly ate her meal. Before she knew it, the clone returned to gather the tray.

"Horde Prime plans to speak with you soon, little sister," the clone said.

Adora shoved the tray into the clone's hands. "What is there to discuss? I don't want to work for him!"

The clone carried the tray into the hallway. "Do not force Prime's hand."

Again, Adora found herself staring at the green void. She rose to her height, then lunged at the barrier. Upon impact, pain flooded her shoulder. She picked up a chair and chucked it forward; the chair skidded backward. What good was she if she couldn't even defend Etheria? Snatches of a conversation wafted into her ears, beckoning her toward the barrier.

"We must not let the prisoner out of our sight," a voice said.

"I agree. The weapon is desperate to escape," another voice replied.

White-hot anger boiled Adora's veins. "Fuck you! I am not a weapon!"

Outside the cell, footsteps began shuffling. Did the shout garner their attention? Adora approached the chair and yanked off a leg. Despite the risk of a potential ambush, she wanted to escape. The chair leg could be a useful weapon. A soft whir of the barrier disappearing interrupted her thoughts; she put the leg back as soon as she removed it.

"Little sister, Horde Prime requests your presence," the clone said.

Adora shot up. "Already?"

"Of course." The clone grabbed Adora's wrist and led her into the hallway. "Prime hopes you're enjoying your stay."

They proceeded through the hallway. Adora's gaze flitted from door to door, scrutinizing the area for a possible exit. At times, a guard or two would acknowledge her presence. Every entrance and exit looked the same. How would anyone find their way around the ship? Did they memorize the layout?

Soon, Adora stepped into what seemed to be a trophy room. Horde Prime waited by the monitors, wearing a serene

expression. She could see through his polite exterior; he might as well drop the act. On one wall, multiple shelves displayed a variety of weapons. On the opposite wall, dozens of artifacts were collecting dust. Clenching her jaw, she made her way to the monitors. Should she steal a staff or a sword and make a run for it?

"Some of my brothers told me that you have been desperate to escape. There is no reason for you to leave," Horde Prime said. "According to a spy, you were fighting with a queen. Will she welcome you back after everything?"

Adora opened her mouth to respond, but Horde Prime continued, not waiting for her to speak. The monitors flashed to life. What she saw took her breath away; the Princess Alliance was defending a Rebel camp. Queen Glimmer's violet eyes shone with a mix of determination and something else Adora couldn't name. Did they know what happened to her?

"She means something to you, doesn't she?" Horde Prime asked, as if reading Adora's mind.

Adora made eye contact. She didn't want to give in to any mind games. If his goal was to break her will, he should forget it. The monitors darkened; she snatched a sword and aimed for Prime's chest. He caught her wrist, tightening his grip. His free hand wrapped around her throat. Within seconds, he took the sword and tossed it across the room. He released Adora's throat. A subtle rage burned in his eyes.

"Normally, I am patient. But because you defied me, you leave me no choice," Horde Prime said.

A chill ran down Adora's spine. Swallowing the rising dread in her heart, she said, "Nothing you do will make me betray my friends! So why don't you just kill me?"

"Killing you will make you a martyr." Horde Prime's grin widened. "I offer you my sincerest apologies if the prototype doesn't work

out."

Prototype?

"Brothers, take the weapon to the purification chamber!" Horde Prime ordered.

The next few moments were a blur. Adora struggled, but failed, to escape her captors' grips as they dragged her into a chamber. An icy chill enveloped her; thousands of green eyes observed her as she felt herself being pushed closer to a green pool. Heart pounding in her chest, her mind raced with ideas on how to flee. Something sharp and metallic pricked the base of her neck.

Let's Talk

Another day went by. There was no new information regarding Adora's whereabouts. However, there was a report of a certain magicat infiltrating the camp. Glimmer led Catra to a tent and used a spell to imprison her. The brunette no longer wore a Force Captain badge, and dark circles surrounded mismatched eyes. The Catra she knew would be much more resistant. Where did Catra's fighting spirit go? Glimmer pointed her staff at the magicat, glowering.

"Why are you here?" Glimmer asked. "You're not working for Horde Prime, are you?"

"No," Catra replied. "Sparkles, can you let me go? All I did was come here."

"Likely story. And where is Double Trouble to make stuff worse?"

"I thought they betrayed me."

"So, what's the real reason you came here? Are you going to surrender?"

Catra crossed her arms. "This interrogation isn't bringing Adora back. Have you considered the possibility of her leaving you behind?"

Glimmer growled. "Adora's loyal to the Rebellion! She'll never betray us."

"Well, did she come back after you and the princesses set off an ancient superweapon? She didn't talk to me after I activated the portal."

"The portal trapped my mother!"

"And where is Adora now?" Catra flashed a smirk. "In captivity? Let's be honest, Sparkles. You're not any better than I am. We

both hurt Adora."

Glimmer lowered her staff. As much as she loathed Catra, her enemy had a point. Still, the magicat did much worse. Who had the audacity to shock Adora for leaving the Horde back in Thaymor? Who left the blonde for dead, manipulated her, and tore up her back? Not to mention making Adora go berserk with the corrupted disk and kidnapping her. And the way Catra spoke to Adora in the portal world that left her suffering from nightmares. The same person also tortured the hero at an outpost.

But Glimmer had hurt Adora, too. She took magic lessons from Shadow Weaver, the woman who abused the blonde. She also used Adora as a decoy and blamed her for Angella's sacrifice. In a sense, she had become another Catra.

"Unlike you, I'm going to make it up to Adora," Glimmer said at last.

"I'll have a talk with Adora, too," Catra replied. "Not because I want to apologize."

"I don't have all day. Bow and I are still trying to figure out how to rescue Adora. Entrapta's taking a while to upgrade Mara's ship, and I'd rather be out there guarding the camp."

"Ugh. I didn't expect an evil kitty to be in here," an exasperated voice said.

Glimmer whirled around. Mermista came forward, glaring at Catra. The others followed; Perfuma, Frosta, Scorpia, and Bow. Shadow Weaver lingered by the tent flap, eyes squinting. Apparently, everyone wanted to have a word with Catra.

"What are you doing here, party pooper?" Frosta spat.

"Catra-" Scorpia began.

"Scorpia, don't start," Catra retorted. "I know none of you like me. You don't have to say it!"

Perfuma clasped her hands together. "Well, you did hurt all of us."

Shadow Weaver approached Catra. "All you do is serve as a hindrance."

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "I should never have fallen for your trick, you old bitch!"

Shadow Weaver summoned her magic. "I will not tolerate your disrespect!"

Bow held up his hands. "Everyone, chill. Catra, if you're going to be with us, just say two words. Say you're sorry."

Catra emitted an audible sigh. "I'm sorry."

Glimmer rested her hands on her hips. "I hope you're being sincere. We still have a much bigger issue to face, and we're not about to waste any more time standing here."

"Okay. Once Mara's ship is ready, can I tag along?" Catra asked.

"I guess you can. You better not try anything funny."

Adora's mind felt hazy, as if she was forgetting something. Peace flooded every inch of her body. Staring out the window, she detected a familiar planet; Etheria. Her home. Something was wrong, yet she couldn't recall why. Unaware of her eyes glowing green, she strode past the clones, carrying a sword in her hand. A vision surfaced; she was back in the cell, waiting for someone to rescue her. A pair of figures peered through the force field, observing her. A small part of her wanted to believe that her friends were here to save her.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked

"Glimmer! Bow! You came!" Adora exclaimed.

"Where's the sword? We need She-Ra."

"I broke the sword."

"She-Ra is our hope, and she can save everyone. Adora can't."

As the vision faded, so did the queen and the archer. Was it how they saw Adora? As a mindless hero who had to protect Etheria from even the most trivial issues? It was a good thing she wasn't working for those helpless people anymore. She could be the hero Prime needed. There was no angry queen here to order her around. Without a single word, she made her way to Horde Prime's throne room and kneeled before him.

"Those you know have always been a pain, haven't they? It is time to put them in their place. You have this power within you, correct?" Horde Prime said.

Adora nodded.

"Little sister, you've become quiet ever since you came into the Light. But it's not an important issue. I wonder how you'll become She-Ra," Horde Prime continued. "There are those you want to put in their place, don't you? And this power will benefit you. If the weak queen, the kitty, and the others beg you to return to them, don't give in. Resist them."

"Yes, Prime," Adora said.

"We will figure out how to activate She-Ra. I have seen your memories of a place called Beast Island. However, the queen hasn't given you any peace, has she? And neither has the kitty and the rest of Etheria. All they have done is hurt you. Anyways, concentrate on summoning She-Ra. First, stand up. Close your eyes. And think about turning into She-Ra."

Adora rose, then took in deep breaths. Another vision surfaced...

...

Adora found herself in a white space, with no hint of color in the vicinity. Pale white transitioned to sickly green as she stepped

forward. Or did she imagine herself moving? A shadow materialized in front of her, five feet away. She couldn't tell who it was, yet their identity didn't matter. Horde Prime's words repeated in her ears. The silhouette transformed into a tall woman with flowing ebony hair, a mask, and a matching dress. Didn't this woman cause her a lot of pain?

"They considered you special when you obeyed..."

Adora blinked; in the woman's place stood a short, regal woman with sparkling pink and purple hair.

"They blamed you for things beyond your control..."

Another blink; a brunette with cat ears and a tail.

"They manipulated you. Left emotional and physical scars. And yet everyone you know..."

Adora prepared to respond, but the voice kept speaking.

A tall, slender woman with wings appeared. "...expected you to be perfect, and to never fail them, ever."

Then, the woman vanished. The voice continued: "Horde Prime won't mind if you fail. All you could do is be the hero he needs, She-Ra..."

...

Adora sensed the power awakening within her as she opened her eyes. She welcomed the bliss that came with serving Horde Prime. He had given her peace, and she didn't want to let go of it anytime. Prime approached her and rested a cold hand on her cheek. She tensed at the touch, a reaction provoked by those who claimed to "love" her.

"Wonderful. I knew you could summon She-Ra. Your place is with me, where you're free," Horde Prime said. "Pain and grief once clouded your mind. Now, they no longer do."

Adora nodded.

"Don't forget what I have done for you," Horde Prime continued.

"I won't," Adora said.

Night surrounded the camp as everyone fell asleep. Glimmer tossed back and forth in her cot, clutching the covers. She couldn't ignore the images that haunted her mind. Heart racing, she struggled to slow her breaths. There was no rest for those who screwed things up, right? Why else would she be fighting with a nightmare? Sweat drenched her hairline and brows as she rolled onto her back...

...

Glimmer was running through a field, searching for Adora. A scream drilled into her ears; her footsteps halted as she glanced in every direction. Did someone hurt Adora? A familiar blonde came into view. Dozens of bots ambushed Adora, shooting lasers at her. Glimmer willed herself to teleport; nothing happened. Why couldn't she intervene? She attempted to cast a spell; same result. As she broke into a run, a clone grabbed Adora from behind. The clone began dragging her to a white spaceship.

"Let Adora go!" Glimmer shouted.

"You're too slow and weak to save her," a voice said.

Glimmer spun around, expecting to see the person who said those words. Instead, what she saw shocked her; multiple bodies bleeding out on the ground, clones chipping her friends, and bots invading camps.

"You've always been small and ineffective. You'll never be like your mother and father. They've always been stronger and better. Why do you even try?"

"Ugh! Whoever you are, why don't you fucking shut up?" Glimmer spat, hoping the invisible speaker would reveal their identity.

The entire world faded to blackness. Glimmer waited for the voice to speak again, yet it didn't. A soft whimper penetrated the silence. Was someone nearby? She looked to the side, her gaze following the sound. Adora was staring blankly at her, not moving a single limb.

"Glimmer? Why did you yell at me?" Adora asked.

"Adora, I'm-"

"Why did you set off the Heart of Etheria?"

Glimmer reached for Adora's hand; the blonde stepped back. A sea of green flooded her vision. Sinister laughter and whispers echoed in the air.

...

Glimmer sat up, panting. It took a moment to remember that she was in the tent instead of a battlefield. Focusing on the outline of furniture and the texture of the blankets, she inhaled deeply. Why was there so much green in the dream? Who was taunting her? Why did she hear whispering and laughing? Swinging her legs over the edge of the bed, she released a soft sigh. She strode out of the tent and took in the fresh air. A cool breeze enveloped her as she dwelled on the voice in the nightmare. Why did she mess things up whenever she tried to be the hero? Should she have left it to her friends to do heroic stuff? None of this would be happening if she had listened to her friends. Maybe there had been another way to take down the Horde, but she thought the superweapon was the only option.

Glimmer wasn't sure if she was fit to carry the title in the first place. What kind of queen would endanger everyone and push friends away? Someone weak and ineffective. A rustle of the bushes interrupted her thoughts; she widened her stance. Purple

orbs encased her fists. Catra stepped forward, holding up her hands.

"It's just me," Catra said.

"I thought it was an intruder. Anyways, weren't you sleeping?" Glimmer replied.

"No. I'm guessing we're the only ones awake right now."

"Yeah."

Catra opened her mouth, then pressed her lips together as she folded her arms. "Were you thinking about Adora?"

"Sort of. What about you?" Glimmer replied.

Catra nodded. "When Adora and I were kids, we made promises to have each other's backs. I have pushed the promise aside after she left the Horde."

"Adora told me that she always stood up for you when growing up. Did you ever defend her?"

Catra shrugged. "Maybe a few times?"

Glimmer lowered her brows. "Did you ever regret hurting her?"

"Why are you asking me?"

"Try to see it from her perspective. Suppose an ex-friend lashes out at you for leaving an evil organization, and later attacks you for making your own choices. They reject you when you tell them to leave the organization, and-"

"Okay, okay. Got it. If I was in Adora's shoes, I'd feel upset about being treated that way." Catra turned to leave. "You and Adora are meant for each other. Don't make the same mistakes as I did."

Glimmer entered the tent, then reclined on the cot. For some reason, sleep didn't come to her. Rolling to her side, she stared at

the folded clothes on the nightstand. They were for Adora, in case something happened to the blonde's usual outfit. She couldn't wait to bring Adora home, safe and sound. Closing her eyes, she remained still, hoping to drift to dreamland. Although, she didn't want the nightmare to return.

An hour after sunrise, Catra made her way to the outskirt of the camp, staring into the distance. Last night, she hadn't anticipated a calm conversation with Glimmer. Somehow they were able to chat without resorting to fighting. And she had seen what Glimmer was capable of. She recalled the moment Glimmer stormed into her base and shot magic blasts everywhere, resulting in a fire. Back then, she hadn't expected the queen to possess so much power. Still, She-Ra was more powerful. Both women could easily take down the Horde together.

Catra wandered past the tents, garnering a few stares from the Rebels. Some of them whispered to one another as they stole glances at her. It didn't take an expert to figure out that they didn't trust her. She was the one who worked with Hordak to conquer Etheria. Excited laughter pierced her ears; she recognized the voice. She gazed in one direction; a short woman with long pigtails babbled about going into space.

A taller woman with short white hair moved past Catra.

"Hey, Scorpia," Catra said, prompting the woman to turn around.

"Oh. Good morning," Scorpia replied.

"About the last time we spoke..." Catra paused, fumbling for the right words to say. "You were right. I wasn't a good friend. I was blinded by my rage, and I didn't appreciate you. One time, I threatened you over the portal thing. There's no excuse for how I treated you. I'm sorry."

"You know, I didn't expect to hear an apology from you. I appreciate the apology, if it's genuine. However, I need time to

think about it."

Once Scorpia walked away, Catra strode to where Entrapta was sitting. The geeky princess scrutinized a tablet while chattering.

"There's no telling where Adora could be! But I'm sure we'll determine her precise location... soon..." Entrapta said.

"Hey, Entrapta," Catra said, startling the small woman.

Entrapta made eye contact before averting her gaze. "I remember you getting mad at me over the portal."

No! I won't! I need to tell Hordak. He'll understand-

Catra sighed. "I came here to apologize-"

"I've always wanted a friend. But I guess I can't because my mind works differently than everyone else's. I get put on a leash, told not to blow stuff up, and..." Entrapta's pigtails balled into fists. "worst of all, you manipulated me into joining the Horde. Hordak was the only one who understood me. Scorpia was a true friend to me, too."

"Sounds like you bottled it up."

Entrapta shook her head. "I process emotions differently."

"Well, I'm sorry," Catra said.

"I hope you're being honest." Entrapta glanced at the tablet. "If you'll excuse me, I'll help Glimmer and Bow find Adora."

Her Hero

Chapter Notes

> There's a part toward the end of the chapter that may be a tearjerker, so grab your tissues beforehand.

Glimmer strode into the main tent after talking to Entrapta and Bow about space exploration. Entrapta said she would track down a signal to determine Adora's location. Right now, the geeky princess was finishing upgrades to Mara's ship. The princesses, except for Perfuma, occupied empty seats, discussing camps and raids. Perfuma and Bow were probably outside, chatting. Glimmer heard Micah and Shadow Weaver arguing. As usual, the sorceress was suggesting harebrained ideas. Activating the Heart of Etheria had made things worse. Who knew how bad it could get if the princesses used it again?

"You don't get to talk to me about Angella!" Micah shouted. "You've always gone after power."

"You used to be my student," Shadow Weaver said.

"Until you used the Spell of Obtainment and joined the Horde."

Shadow Weaver stormed to the tent flap. "At least I'm not working for Horde Prime!"

Glimmer scowled at Shadow Weaver. "Fuck off. No one asked for your suggestions! We're sick of your shit."

Shadow Weaver stepped out of the tent. "If your mother was here-"

"Shut up. Leave us alone."

Glimmer watched as the sorceress walked away. The witch better not try anything. If Shadow Weaver did, she wouldn't hesitate to punish her. That bitch didn't learn anything from being punched in

the Black Garnet Chamber. Glimmer approached the table, scrutinizing the map.

"Why do you trust Entrapta and Catra?" Mermista asked.

"Entrapta's helping us rescue Adora," Glimmer said. "As for Catra, she's starting to change."

"Catra didn't say a single apology about Salineas. And Entrapta would betray us as soon as she sees the Galactic Horde's technology."

Frosta crossed her arms. "Did she say anything about Princess Prom?"

Scorpia frowned. "Can you guys give Entrapta a chance? Her brain doesn't work like ours. Also, Catra may have been mean, but maybe there's a tiny bit of good in her."

Mermista rolled her eyes. "Of course someone from the Horde would make excuses for their actions."

Glimmer sighed. "Let me tell you this. Adora was from the Horde, right? And you didn't hold her past against her."

"She's different."

"Because she's She-Ra?" Glimmer arched her brows. "She was like the rest of them, and then she left. It was the right thing for her to do. Some people change, and others stay the same. Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, remained manipulative and power-hungry."

Glimmer waited for a response. Then, she continued, "Bow, Entrapta, and I will go into space and bring Adora back. We need to figure something out, She-Ra or not. We can't afford to lose anyone else. Besides, we already lost Adora."

Catra leaned against a tree, watching the sorcerers maintain the magical barrier. From time to time, cracks would form. It seemed as if they were struggling to keep it up. Maybe people would be safer if they went somewhere hidden. But then again, they might not consider the possibility of moving to a concealed hideout. Her old base in the woods would have been much safer than this. The sound of crunching leaves garnered her attention; every hair on her body and tail bristled as she extended her claws.

"Catra, no one here needs you," Shadow Weaver said.

"Why are you still here?" Catra spat.

"I'm helping the Rebellion. So far, no one appreciated me."

"Because manipulation has always been your thing."

"I'm not the bad guy here. You kidnapped Adora and set off the portal. You always stood in the way of her potential."

Catra straightened her spine. "Who used dark magic on me? Who physically abused me? They point to the same answer; you." She narrowed her eyes. There would be nothing for Shadow Weaver to latch onto. "You didn't care what could have happened to me after you escaped your cell. You preferred Adora over me, all because she's somehow special due to her power. I'm surprised you're not imprisoned for your crimes."

"You're not innocent, either."

"I'm trying to make it up to those I hurt. And what have you been doing?" Catra's nostrils flared. "Going around, trying to tell people to do what you want?"

"Is your idea of redemption showing disrespect to the woman who raised you?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Catra suspected that Shadow Weaver was anticipating a reaction. As much as she wanted to sock the old hag, she restrained herself. "What is your idea of respect?"

Shadow Weaver paused, as if trying to come up with a response. Then, she said, "If you'll excuse me, I'll be in my tent."

Once again, Catra was alone. She felt proud of herself for telling Shadow Weaver to go away without resorting to violence, although a dark part of her wanted to carve a few scars. An explosion boomed in the distance. Snatches of conversations pierced the air as another explosion roared. A blast shattered the barrier. Every muscle in her body hardened as she sprung to action. The Princess Alliance and their friends fought multitudes of bots and clones. She lunged at the drones, slicing every single one with her claws. A pair of teens stared at her as she took down yet another bot. A feral scream drilled into her ears; she glanced up to see Glimmer blasting dozens of drones at once. The queen zipped out of this reality and reappeared in another spot, then unleashed a huge purple sphere at the clones. More punches, kicks, and various moves followed.

Catra thought of the time when Glimmer's magic was limited. What would past Sparkles think of current Sparkles? Would *she* be impressed? Surprised at how powerful *her* future self became? Unaware of an enemy approaching, she continued gawking at the queen. A hot sensation collided into her spine, knocking her off her feet.

Catra rolled onto her back; a group of clones and bots surrounded her. One of them pointed an arm cannon at her. She surveyed the group for an opening, a weakness. She didn't see any. Somehow they had considered the possibility of fighting magicats. Pain flooded her back as she forced herself to rise. Another beam carved a bloody line from her knee to her ankle. A scream of agony erupted from her throat. A clone grabbed her from behind, perhaps with the intent to kidnap her.

Arrows and lightning bolts slammed into every bot and clone, including the one holding Catra. Tendrils of water washed the bots away; vines restrained the clones. She looked up to see who protected her.

"Are you okay?" Bow asked.

"What does this look like to you, Arrow Boy?" Catra replied.

Scorpia lifted Catra off the ground, cradling her. "Don't move too much. Someone's going to patch you up."

"Great. I was going to get on Mara's ship with Arrow Boy and Sparkles, and now I'm out of commission."

Glimmer reappeared, then beckoned everyone forward. "We've got to go somewhere else! They invaded this camp!"

Later in the day, Glimmer and the others set up camp in the middle of the woods. Catra had entered the infirmary tent with those who got injured. It was yet another day without Adora. Sighing, Glimmer kicked a pebble across the ground. How was the blonde feeling right now? Alone? Scared? Had Adora given up hope of being rescued? Inhaling the scent of patchouli and sandalwood, she wandered toward her tent. Tears streamed down her cheeks. She shook her head, reminding herself to be strong for Adora.

However, would Glimmer even be able to save Adora? She had always needed someone to help her. And if she tried to be heroic, a quality reserved for knights in fairy tales, her efforts would backfire. Who would escape the magical restraints and wind up with glitching powers? Who would yell at one's mother and hurry to the Fright Zone? Eventually, every thought of her failures whizzed through her mind. She descended to her knees, sobbing. Maybe she should have stayed out of the fight, like Angella did.

A hand rested on Glimmer's shoulder, drawing her attention. She expected to see Bow; instead, Micah was sitting next to her, caressing her back.

"Is something the matter, sweetheart?" Micah asked. "I haven't comforted anyone, so I'm just going by what your aunt told me to say to you."

"It's fine. You were gone for years. But that's not what's on my mind. Adora is. I was awful to her, and I set off the Heart of Etheria. Now Horde Prime could be holding her hostage," Glimmer said. "I want... to be a hero to her. And I can't."

"Sounds similar to what Adora told me on Beast Island. You're somewhat alike. So, tell me about her."

Glimmer sniffled. "She's awesome. Strong, kind, has the most adorable laugh, and always puts herself second, even at the risk of her life. Adora is the best thing that has ever happened to me, and now... it's like... having a gift be cruelly taken away from you. I miss her."

"Don't lose hope," Micah said. "I never gave up on seeing you, your mother, and Casta again. And guess what? I came back. I have a feeling Adora will come back to you."

Glimmer couldn't see how she could avoid losing hope. There was a rift between her and Adora, and they might not forgive each other. And who knew what Horde Prime could be doing to Adora? Would she ever have the strength to save her from his clutches? She had failed Adora when the blonde needed her most.

Soon, Micah rose to his height and walked away. Glimmer strode into her tent. She approached the folded clothes; a journal rested on top. Adora's journal. She had given it to Adora shortly after the hero left the Horde. What could be going through Adora's mind as of late? Picking up the journal, she sat on the cot and flipped through the pages. It didn't take long to discover the recent entries. Dried teardrops and ink stains dotted the pages.

...

> Dear diary,
>
> It has been a while since I last wrote. Those past few weeks are hard. There never seemed to be a moment of peace between me and Glimmer. Angella told me to take care of her, yet it feels as if I'm screwing everything up. Maybe I should

have taken the sword in the portal reality instead. That way, Glimmer and the others would be happy. I missed how close we were; I'm tired of waking up from nightmares and finding no comfort. She used to be there to hug me whenever I had a nightmare. And now? She's angry all the time.

Why did I pick up the Sword of Protection in the first place? Everything got worse ever since the day I became She-Ra. Wasn't She-Ra supposed to bring hope to the Rebellion? It hurt to try and do one's best when I keep falling short.

Why does being She-Ra hurt so much? If I was good enough, Etheria would be a lot better by now. Instead, everything's falling to shit.

What's the point of being the hero if all I do is fuck things up?

...

As Glimmer read the words, she imagined hearing the tears in Adora's voice. She ached to reach out and hold her tight. But they were a million miles apart. Closing the book, she held it against her chest, imagining herself holding Adora.

"Adora..." Glimmer whispered. "I'm so sorry..."

Adora never said anything about her inner turmoil. Not even a single word. Somewhere along the way, she had turned to the journal as her source of comfort. Poor Adora. Glimmer placed the book onto the pile of clothes. It was never her intention to upset the blonde, even if she did yell at her about Angella's demise.

Glimmer lowered her head, burying her face in her hands. Unable to hold back the tears, she let the droplets fall onto her palms. She remained in place; not once did she move a single limb. An hour dragged on, and she reclined on the cot. As soon as she closed her eyes, she slipped into a vision...

...

A tall, slender woman with dual-toned hair materialized in front of Glimmer, wings shimmering in the light. Angella wore a serene smile as she made eye contact. Glimmer's heart ached; she didn't think she would see her mother again. Did the former queen come to her just now?

"Mom?" Glimmer breathed out. "How are you here?"

"I've been watching over you," Angella said.

"I was a horrible daughter and queen. And I was awful to Adora, too. I'm sorry for everything." Glimmer propelled herself into Angella's embrace. "I guess I'm not meant to be queen, let alone have a friend like Adora."

"I have already forgiven you, even when you thought otherwise."

"You forgave me?" Glimmer gazed into Angella's eyes. "Even though I was a brat?"

"I did."

"You're a better queen than I am."

Angella smiled. "You should have seen my younger self. I didn't make the wisest decisions. Like you, I was impulsive."

"Somehow I couldn't imagine you being that way," Glimmer said. "I tried to be the hero, and everyone got hurt. Horde Prime has Adora in his clutches. I should have left the hero thing to her."

"Sweetie, don't be hard on yourself. You're a strong woman, and-"

"I can't take care of Adora."

"Yes, you can. She has always taken care of you. I've seen the way you were around her. If she can fight for you, you can fight for her." Angella stroked Glimmer's cheek. "Anyone can be a hero. It takes courage and a heart of selflessness."

"Even me?" Glimmer asked.

"Of course. I'm about to go. You must keep my words in mind. I'm proud of you, and will always be."

...

Glimmer's eyes fluttered open. Did she just talk to her mother? Did Angella's spirit visit her in the vision? And most importantly, how in the world would she fight for Adora?

Save the Blonde

As Catra waited for her body to heal, Entrapta tracked down a signal at a spire. The geeky princess had determined Adora's location. Since a blockade was coming, Glimmer and her friends acted as soon as possible. The Rebels faked a surrender, allowing Glimmer, Bow, Catra, and Entrapta to board Mara's ship. It didn't take long for the vessel to launch. They were one step closer to rescuing Adora.

Once the vessel was in space, Glimmer made her way to the window, gazing at the twinkling stars. Catra sat next to the window, leaning against the glass. The magicat still had a limp in her step whenever she walked around. At least the brunette's wound healed a little. Behind them, Bow and Entrapta were discussing the ship. For some reason, Entrapta decided to name the vessel Darla.

"It felt right," Entrapta had said.

Within minutes, the ship stalled. Entrapta pulled apart the wall circuitry and crawled into a tunnel, then began her tinkering. Didn't she say she finished upgrading Darla before launch? Did she overlook an issue or two? Bow proceeded to follow her around the vessel, trying to tell her to wait until after the group retrieved Adora. But Entrapta didn't listen; instead, she continued messing with the technology. Glimmer massaged her temples, releasing a frustrated groan as she waited for the geeky princess to finish up already. Catra's eye-roll mirrored her current feelings regarding the situation.

"Isn't saving Adora more important?" Glimmer asked.

"This is Entrapta we're talking about," Catra said. "Her priorities weren't always right."

"You once sent her to Beast Island."

"I know. You don't have to mention that. So..." Catra moved away from the window, her feet meeting the floor. "You ready to get Adora back?"

"I sure am. We'll get this done with, assuming the plan doesn't backfire."

"You guys didn't always make the best plans."

"Even if there were mistakes, we don't let any of that stop us."

Catra crossed her arms. "I can't deny that you guys are determined. Even when everything's going to shit, you're trying to save the world."

Glimmer tilted her head. "Don't you want a home to return to?"

"Yeah, I do."

"And isn't there someone who means something to you? Scorpia, for example? What would you do if something happens to her?"

Catra's ears flickered. "I kind of care about her. I wouldn't be happy if I lose her."

Glimmer thought of her initial reaction to Adora getting captured. "It's how I feel. About Horde Prime holding Adora hostage, I mean. If he tries anything, I won't hesitate to make sure he no longer hurts Adora."

"You've always been super protective of her."

"True, ever since she joined the Rebellion." Glimmer sighed. "I know she can take care of herself, but there were times when she rushed into danger."

"I'm sure you do that, too." Catra strode to the chair. "Both of you can be reckless."

As they continued the conversation, Bow and Entrapta returned. He said, "Entrapta fixed the ship. We should reach Horde Prime's ship in no time."

"Time to storm his place." Catra's tail swished to one side. "On a serious note, though, we have to plan out the entire mission."

Fifteen minutes whizzed by as Darla glided closer and closer to their destination. Eventually, the vessel landed on a platform on Horde Prime's ship. The crew came up with a plan; while Bow and Entrapta would hack the computer system, Glimmer and Catra would search for Adora.

Glimmer and Catra explored the ship, avoiding clones as they navigated every room and hallway. This was more confusing than the Fright Zone; there were intersections everywhere. At one point, Catra commented on the layout. They stepped into a spacious room with a platform and a throne. A white-clad figure occupied the throne, observing them. Glimmer shuddered at the sight of his green eyes. This was Horde Prime, right? Swallowing her nervousness, she proceeded forward. Catra grabbed her wrist, holding her back.

"He gives me the creeps," Catra said.

Glimmer bit her lip. "I can't blame you. Still, we're not backing out."

"Oh, so a pair of little sisters decided to pay a visit," the man said, slowly rising to his height.

"Where is Adora?" Glimmer spat through clenched teeth.

"Ah, so you are the queen from her memories. And the kitty is the one who grew up in my brother's former home, correct?"

Disgust overwhelmed Glimmer's stomach; she felt as if she could puke. "How were you able to see Adora's mind, chalk-face?"

Horde Prime gestured to the shadows. "Come, She-Ra."

"She... what?"

"You heard me correctly, Your Majesty."

A hooded figure emerged, moving forward. A pair of hands pushed back the hood, revealing Adora. Her hair was pulled back in a neat bun, with no hair out of place. She wore a Horde uniform, a mockery of her She-Ra form. And to top it all off, her eyes glowed green, concealing every trace of her bright blue eyes.

"I have made her anew. She was in so much grief and pain... And I brought her into the Light," Horde Prime said. "Isn't that right, little sister?" He stroked Adora's cheek, eliciting a gasp from her.

"Let Adora go!" Glimmer shouted.

Horde Prime chuckled. "She works for me now. Little sister, tell them what I've done for you."

Adora glanced at Glimmer. "Prime has given me peace. You broke my heart, and he has made it whole."

"Adora, you have to fight it!" Glimmer said.

"I am not taking orders from you." Adora turned her attention to Catra. "I thought I told you to leave me alone. Don't you see, girls? I'm happy here. My place is with Horde Prime."

Horde Prime beckoned a clone forward. The clone handed a sword to Adora. "I have what I need, and I won't let go of my asset. You Etherians have hailed She-Ra as your hero. Now she is mine." He patted Adora's head. "You three must have a lot of catching up to do. I will leave you to it."

Horde Prime left the room. Glimmer hated the way he was touching Adora. The Adora she knew wouldn't consent to unwelcome touches. The way he was caressing the blonde, it made her think of an unpleasant word. More like, an action being forced on someone. Had he been doing this to Adora for a while?

"Adora, we're here to take you home," Glimmer said. "You're not safe here."

"You're kidding, right? I never felt safe on Etheria. I always drove myself crazy trying to please everyone, especially you," Adora said. The words sounded so wrong, coming out of her. "Here, I don't have to worry about disappointing anyone." She held up her sword. "For the glory of Prime!"

Unlike a majestic transformation, Adora's current one seemed painful. She screamed in agony as her limbs stretched and thickened, muscles bulging. Glimmer and Catra exchanged glances, then looked at Adora. They were about to deal with a She-Ra who wouldn't hold back. Adora lunged at them, swinging the sword through the air. Glimmer teleported out of the way, then reappeared behind the blonde. She detected something on Adora's neck.

"Something on her neck is controlling her," Glimmer said.

"Like how he controls the clones?" Catra asked as she dodged an attack.

"Of course! It's not the first time someone tried to control Adora."

"I'm not the one doing it. Prime is!"

"I know. Try not to make a big deal of it. She could catch on, Prime could catch on - fuck!" Glimmer teleported again to avoid an incoming blow. "Catra, let's work together and rescue her from his control."

Glimmer and Catra worked together, wasting no time to search for an opening. However, each time they thought they did, Adora would outsmart them. Adora kicked Catra's abdomen; Catra flew across the platform. Laughter erupted from the blonde's throat. It wasn't the laugh Glimmer had grown to love; it sounded cold and sadistic. She missed the adorably joyful sound of the blonde's infectious laugh.

Glimmer traced a rune in the air; Adora dodged the spell.

"Horde Prime, this isn't fair to Adora!" Glimmer shouted. "You're forcing her to do stuff she wouldn't do!"

Then again, he sure isn't the type to play fair. And he's the worst.

"Want to know what's not fair?" Adora spat. "Whenever I try to fix things, all I seem to do is piss you off! Horde Prime isn't forcing me to do anything. I serve him, not you."

"Adora, I know you're in there. I know you don't want to hurt me, despite everything-" Glimmer began.

Adora swung her sword at Glimmer's leg; Glimmer zipped through another dimension and reappeared by Catra's side.

"I'm guessing the words didn't work," Catra said as she rose, grunting in pain. "I'll use brute force-"

"She-Ra's stronger, you know."

"What's the best course of action?"

"We'll try our best."

"There's got to be something. Anything to get Adora back to her usual dumb self. Her usual self isn't unhinged."

A furious scream interrupted their conversation; Glimmer teleported Catra out of the way before Adora could murder them. In a swift motion, she traced a rune and unleashed a spell toward the chip. Adora staggered forward, landing on the floor. The blonde rolled onto her back, eyes bright blue instead of empty green voids. Tears glistened in Adora's eyes as she stared at Glimmer and Catra.

"Why?" Adora asked.

"Why what?" Glimmer asked. As if she didn't know; she once blamed Adora for Angella's sacrifice.

"Why did you blame me for your mother's sacrifice? Why did you say I wasn't good enough?"

"Adora, I'm so-"

"Catra, I never did anything to you. Have you lived with - ugh!"

Green replaced bright blue as Adora forced herself up. "I'll finish what Horde Prime told me to do!"

"Guess the chip is more formidable than it appeared," Catra commented.

"Clearly he doesn't want to let her go!" Glimmer replied as she cast another rune.

Adora closed the distance between herself and Catra, grabbed the magicat's neck, and held her over the abyss, allowing her to dangle. "You will no longer cause me any pain. Any last words before you fall to your doom?"

Catra rammed her foot into Adora's stomach. "Let me go!"

Adora yelped in pain as she released Catra and fell to her knees. Catra gripped the ledge for dear life. Adora charged at Glimmer; the queen blocked the sword with a staff. Glimmer continued parrying multiple blows, frantically searching for a weakness.

If she can fight for you, you can fight for her.

"Getting tired?" Adora asked.

"No. I will never give up! I will fight for you! You are not Horde Prime's soldier. Adora, you are a hero. And you'll always be a hero in my eyes!" Glimmer shouted.

For a moment, Adora faltered. Her eyes turned from sickly green to bright blue. "Are you saying this for real? Or are you just - agh!" Once again, her eyes were a sea of green.

"I'm being real! Adora, come back to me! We need you. I need you!"

For the next several seconds, Adora's eyes continued changing color. The chip on her neck crackled and hissed as she moaned in pain and clutched her nape. "I... I am not... a - ow! Please stop torturing me! Glim... I can't turn into She-Ra. Go ahead. Put me down. As long as he's controlling me, I'll be a danger to you... I can't be the hero you deserved!"

"I'm not going to end your life," Glimmer said.

"What are you - agh! He's doing it again!"

"You can fight him!"

Just then, Prime overrode Adora. "Pathetic. You have tainted this vessel. I have no need of She-Ra anyways. I will take over Etheria, with or without her."

Before Glimmer knew it, Adora stumbled into the abyss, screaming. She was not about to let Horde Prime hurt Adora anymore. A strange sensation filled her back as she leapt off the ledge; out of the corner of her eyes, she spied translucent wings at her sides. How did they? She thought she would never have wings like Angella's. Reminding herself to save her surprise for later, she dove toward the bottom and caught Adora before the woman could land.

"I got you, Starlight. Please tell me you're okay... tell me you're alright..." Glimmer whispered as she descended onto her knees. Clenching her hand into a fist, she punched the chip. "Adora, wake up."

A terrified wail drilled into Glimmer's ears; she heard a thud behind her. Catra must have fallen to the bottom. This was not

going according to plan. And Adora wasn't recovering from the chip's power. What exactly did he do to her? White-hot rage fueled her body as she watched the clones approach. She sensed the fire burning within her soul as she rose.

"I will not let you hurt anyone else, Horde Prime!" Glimmer screeched, her voice echoing off the walls. She slammed her staff into the floor, creating a shockwave that caused the clones to fall.

Glimmer shot kinetic blasts at her foes, keeping them at bay. She grabbed Adora and Catra, then teleported them to Mara's ship. Panting from exerting most of her magic reserves, she dragged both women to the cockpit. As Entrapta and Bow barged into the ship, the door slammed shut.

"You have wings now?" Entrapta asked in a fascinated tone.

"They're cool, but we have to make sure the girls are okay," Glimmer said. "Horde Prime did a number on them!"

"Is Adora okay? She doesn't seem to be breathing," Bow pointed out. "And I could say the same about Catra."

"Entrapta, move Darla out of Horde Prime's ship as fast as possible. We can't let him capture Adora."

Adora's eyes fluttered open as she took in her surroundings. She was on a cot, and in a room, but where? This didn't look anything like her cell. A dull pain throbbed in the back of her neck, and she reached for the spot. Was this real, or another one of Horde Prime's illusions? Subtle chatter wafted into the room; they weren't robotic in tone. The door slid open, revealing a winged figure. Their hair and outfit seemed familiar. It dawned on her; Glimmer was in here. But how? And why? Was she dreaming?

"Adora, you're awake," Glimmer said as she rushed to Adora's side. "How are you feeling?"

"Where... where am I?" Adora asked.

"On Mara's ship. Entrapta called it Darla."

Adora sat up, head aching as she tried to remember what happened prior to this. Her gaze landed on a trash bag, glimpsing an uniform. "Why does everything hurt? Why does my neck feel weird?"

Glimmer took in a deep breath. "Horde Prime controlled you with a chip."

Suddenly, Adora was on Horde Prime's ship, attacking Glimmer and Catra. Flashes and scenes of her chipped self flooded her brain, and she fought to stop the memories from coming. But they continued their assault, freezing her in place. The air rushed out of her lungs, and hot tears streamed down her face. Her heart drummed her ribs, threatening to jump out. Glimmer's voice drew her back to reality; the shorter woman drew her into an embrace, wings enveloping her trembling body.

Beating Hearts

Glimmer caressed Adora's back as the blonde continued crying. Adora had gone through so much, and Prime's mind control topped it all off. After thirty minutes, the blonde calmed down, letting out an occasional hiccup. Even if her friend was calm, she didn't want to let go. A part of her feared losing Adora again. She would rather keep her safe. As long as she was nearby, nothing would happen to Adora. Footsteps entered the room, garnering her attention as she let Adora recline on the cot.

"Is she okay?" Bow asked.

"She had been crying," Glimmer said.

Catra stepped into the room, limping. "Is Adora - whoa, Sparkles. Since when did you get wings?"

Glimmer glanced at Adora, whose eyes were half-closed. "Can you guys try not to overwhelm her? I get that the wings appeared out of nowhere, but-"

Adora sat up. "Catra, I don't want to see you."

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "This is the thanks I get for helping Sparkles rescue you? I know I did a lot of bad stuff in the past, but I'm trying to make it up to you guys."

Glimmer lowered her brows. "You heard Adora."

"I was gonna go back to my room anyways."

Once Catra and Bow left the room, Glimmer looked into Adora's eyes. There was so much she wanted to say. Especially what Adora deserved to hear. Unspoken words lingered in the air, waiting to be heard. She held the blonde's hands.

"Adora, I'm sorry for everything I've said to you. My mother's sacrifice isn't your fault. She did it so she could save us. I haven't

had the chance to process my grief because I was busy with royal responsibilities and trying so hard to keep Etheria safe. I also felt as if no one listened to me. None of it excused what I did. I won't blame you if you don't want to forgive me."

"Glimmer... thank you for the apology," Adora said. "I'm sorry, too. I was so focused on keeping you safe, I ended up driving you away. You're an amazing queen, and you're..." Her gaze drifted to Glimmer's wings. "Beautiful. How did you get wings?"

"They appeared when you fell into the abyss. I caught you."

"Wow... you saved me..."

"I couldn't bear to see you get hurt." Glimmer thought of the moment she lashed out at the clones. "While you were unconscious, Horde Prime's clones approached us. And I slammed my staff into the floor to create a shockwave. I was mad at Prime for what he did to you."

"Whoa," Adora breathed out. "Well, speaking of Prime, I need to stop him. Etheria needs me to be a hero."

"Can you take a break?" Glimmer prepared to say something about Adora's She-Ra form. Instead, she bit her tongue. "Everyone is taking a break at the moment."

"Okay, I will."

"Good. And I'm here whenever you need me."

Darla landed on the Crystal planet due to running low on fuel. While Glimmer, Adora, and Bow set out to gather the fuel, Catra remained on the ship. She didn't have a lot to do in here, except talk to Entrapta or look at the comm pad. Her body still ached from the fight, as though a tank rolled over her. She had heard Glimmer mention teleporting her and Adora to Mara's ship after a moment of lashing out at their enemies. Sure, Glimmer wasn't She-Ra, but she must have packed quite a punch.

Catra picked up the comm pad, then settled in the captain's chair. The screen flashed to life, revealing Perfuma.

"Catra?" Perfuma asked. "How are the others?"

"They're good. Right now, they're getting the fuel for Darla."

"Darla?"

"Short for Mara's ship. Entrapta chose the name." Catra leaned back in the chair. "So, how's Etheria?"

"Etheria's still in danger. And did you guys get Adora back?"

"Yeah. It was hard because Horde Prime chipped her. He wanted to use her."

Perfuma furrowed her brows. "She's okay now, right?"

"Yes," Catra said. "She didn't want to see me, though."

"You did hurt her."

"I know. Anyways, I want to say hi to Scorpia."

Perfuma smiled. "Funny you should say that. She was talking about you earlier."

"She was?"

"Yeah. She misses you." The camera moved as Perfuma walked to a tent.

Scorpia appeared on the screen. "Hello, wildcat."

"Hey, Scorpia," Catra said.

"Did you guys save Adora?"

"We did." Catra proceeded to tell Scorpia the whole story.

A familiar alicorn joined Scorpia. "Did someone say Swift Wind? I'm sure She-Ra did."

"Swift Wind, in case you're wondering, Horde Prime tapped into Adora's power. That's probably how you sensed her. No one asked for you. Scorpia and I are talking, and she hasn't said anything about the story."

Scorpia held up a pincer. "So, talking horses aside, the story was intense. How's Adora at the moment?"

"She's okay," Catra said. "I'm surprised she hasn't gotten brain damage. It must be the hair poof."

"Isn't she affected in any way?"

"I think they said something about her crying. Horde Prime's a piece of shit for trying to control her."

"Is he worse than Hordak?"

Catra nodded dramatically. "Of course! A thousand times worse. And creepier, I must add. The worst Hordak could do was tell us to get out. Remember those times?"

Scorpia smiled. "Yes. Somehow he has the decency to be kind to Entrapta, as scary as he had been."

"Hordak's still with Horde Prime. He won't see Entrapta again."

"Do you think they could try?"

"To be honest, it's unlikely they would. Horde Prime controls the clones, and Entrapta wouldn't tell the difference between any of them."

"You have a point. Those clones look the same."

Catra and Scorpia continued the conversation until Darla's door opened. She turned off the comm pad and began walking to her

room when Adora stopped her. What did the blonde want? Wasn't Adora still mad over what Catra did?

"Is it true you're trying to change?" Adora asked.

"It's true. I'm sorry for scratching you and being nasty to you," Catra said.

"I may not be able to forgive you."

"No wonder you didn't hold back while controlled."

"Because I let Prime take over. I wouldn't hurt Glimmer, but I could sock you if you try anything. Are you living with your choices?"

Catra shrugged. "I guess you could say that."

"There's no guarantee we will talk again after all of this is over."

Adora was walking through a hallway on the Velvet Glove, unsure of her destination. The temperature sank as she strode to an intersection. Staring into a pair of corridors, one dark, and one light, she listened for footsteps. The entire place seemed empty. Sinister laughter echoed off the walls. She sensed an evil presence approaching. Should she look? Seriously, how did she wind up back on Horde Prime's ship in the first place? Did he kidnap her again?

"She-Ra, you thought you could get away from me. I'm hoping you would return to me," a smooth voice said.

Adora whirled around. Horde Prime loomed over her, scrutinizing every inch of her body. He pressed an icy palm against her cheek, then dragged his hand to her neck. The hairs on her body stood. His wide smile creeped her out. A chill stampeded up and down her spine as she stepped back. He grabbed her wrist; she rammed a fist into his forearm. Yet he didn't budge.

"Your resistance is futile. I'm surprised the weak queen managed to steal you from me," Horde Prime said. "She has never wanted you in the first place. Why go back to those who caused you pain and grief?"

"Leave them alone," Adora said.

"You'll join those misguided souls?" Anger seeped into Horde Prime's voice as he spoke. Despite that, he maintained a calm exterior. "Unless you surrender to me, I will destroy everyone and everything you hold so dear."

"I will rather die than let you win."

"Once I cleanse Etheria, it's over for everyone, even you. What a shame. You could have been a great warrior for my army."

The hallway began glitching. Adora glowered at Horde Prime; the warlord snickered, as if her defiance meant nothing. The floor gave way beneath her, and she fell into a dark chasm.

...

Adora bolted awake, panting as her mind took several seconds to catch up. An urge to fight or flee the threat overwhelmed every muscle in her body as she rolled off the cot. How was Horde Prime still going after her? Could he still see into her mind? Was the chip not removed? Her breath came in shallow pants, as if inhaling through a straw. A warm hand met her shoulder; she rolled onto her back. Glimmer stared into her eyes, frowning.

"Adora, count backward from one hundred," Glimmer said.

Adora counted backward; her heartbeat slowed down, as did her breathing.

"What's wrong? I heard a noise coming from your room."

"I... I saw him," Adora said. "I'm not chipped, am I?"

"No. Entrapta removed that thing," Glimmer replied.

"Yet I'm able to see him either way. How is it happening?"

"I don't know. You're safe here; no one and nothing will hurt you." Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand, helping her rise. "Do you need to go back to sleep?"

Adora thought of the nightmare. "I... I don't want to."

"How about a cuddle? It may make you feel better."

Adora's heart fluttered at the suggestion. She thought of those nights when she cuddled with the queen after a nightmare. Glimmer's presence radiated comfort.

"Maybe," Adora said at last. "I missed the nighttime cuddles."

"Same," Glimmer replied, leading Adora to the cot. "I'll keep the nightmares away. And I'll make sure Horde Prime doesn't touch you."

The two women reclined on the cot, figuring out their positions until they settled on one that wouldn't restrict Glimmer's wings. Adora rested her head on Glimmer's chest; the shorter woman wrapped her arms around the blonde's waist. Glimmer's wings draped over both women. Adora became aware of the queen's heartbeat as she took in deep breaths. Warmth bloomed in her limbs. A subtle desire to fall asleep niggled at the edges of her consciousness.

"Feeling better?" Glimmer whispered.

"Yes," Adora replied.

"I'm glad to hear that. I love you, Starlight."

"Love you too, Glitter-bug. Anyways, when do you think we're going home?"

"Not sure. I hope as soon as possible, so that we'll be there for our friends. We can't afford to lose more people."

"I agree. And I need to be able to turn into She-Ra."

"We'll still figure it out, She-Ra or no She-Ra. Your safety was the most important thing to me when I came to space."

Adora sighed. "Thanks for saving me."

"I'd do anything for you," Glimmer said.

"I'd do anything for you, too. We'll always have each other's backs."

"We're stronger together."

Catra had never imagined herself as a nice or caring person. Her old life in the Horde had hardened her, and she had reached a point where she didn't care about anyone. Back then, she considered friendships something to avoid. These days, however, she was improving as a person. Of course, there were still times when she wanted to scream at someone or flat-out attack them. Perhaps the recent events were a wake-up call, after all. And to think that she was on the receiving end of a chipped She-Ra... In a sense, Horde Prime had unlocked all of Adora's anger. She wandered toward the window, gazing at stars and different planets.

As Darla glided toward Etheria, Catra detected hundreds of ships moving in a specific direction. Did Horde Prime ask his minions to barricade Etheria yet? As she turned to glance at Bow, the archer held up the comm pad. She could hear Perfuma's frantic voice. Did something go wrong?

"Perfuma, slow down. What's wrong?" Bow said.

"Horde Prime has set up a trap so he can capture Adora again. And his army will kill the rest of you. Don't come home!" Perfuma

replied.

"Oh, no. How long were we away?"

"A couple days, maybe? Stay safe out there!"

"You stay safe, too."

Catra rushed toward Bow, and before she could add anything to the conversation, the comm pad's screen darkened. She was going to ask about Scorpia! And now she wouldn't know if the scorpioni woman was okay. Unless anyone did anything, their friends and the rest of Etheria were toast. Adora and Glimmer would hate to hear the bad news. And due to a hero complex, the blonde would feel overwhelmed.

"I was about to ask her if Scorpia was alright," Catra said.

"We'll have to tell Adora and Glimmer," Bow replied.

"Tell us what?" A confused voice asked, garnering their attention to the door.

Adora and Glimmer stood in the doorway, observing them. The queen strode toward the captain's chair, Adora following close behind. Did they overhear the conversation? Catra peeked at Entrapta; the geeky princess was in the middle of tapping the control console.

"We can't go to Etheria. There's a barricade. If we try to go through, we won't make it," Bow explained.

"Oh, great." Adora massaged her temples. "Without She-Ra, I'm no good."

Glimmer shrugged. "I could teleport all of us."

Catra shook her head. "We could get caught reappearing somewhere."

"Any better ideas?"

Bow held up a finger. "Adora, you were on Prime's ship. Did he have any weaknesses?"

Adora released an audible exhale. "I don't think he'd say anything about a weakness." Then, she squeezed her eyes. "Wait, I remember something." She hugged herself as she spoke. "He mentioned a planet named Krytis. He must have seen something on there."

Entrapta stroked her chin. "The interface did show something. However, it's locked and requires administrator clearance."

Adora's eyes opened. "Darla, show us."

The interface revealed a star map. Entrapta said, "According to Darla's records, it's located nearby."

Krytis

Chapter Notes

> This is one of the chapters in the story that'll show a POV other than Catra's, Glimmer's, and Adora's.
>
> How do you think Catra's redemption is going in this fic? Am I doing her any justice?
>
> Did I write Adora's trauma well?

Darla landed in Krytis, a deserted planet with a toppled spire. Or at least, this place seemed abandoned. If Krytis was Horde Prime's weakness, it meant he had seen something here. Adora followed the others down a rocky precipice to the spire. As she rubbed her neck, a phantom sensation of metal penetrating her flesh tingled. Her mind flashed to the moment the clones shoved her into the green pool. Her lungs had burned for air as the water electrocuted her. Shuddering, she caught up with the rest of the group. The scene continued replaying, despite her effort to suppress the memories of the Velvet Glove. Shouldn't heroes focus on saving the world, not on their traumas?

"The atmosphere is safe," Entrapta said, giggling as she checked her tablet. "I picked up a heat signature. There is someone on this planet, right here, somewhere in the spire."

"We have to find them," Adora said as she and the group removed their helmets.

Entrapta tossed the earpieces to the Best Friend Squad and Catra. "Pulling up the spire's schematics now. I'll guide you from here."

"So, wait, the plan is to explore the unstable place and find someone we know nothing about. As if they know how to defeat Horde Prime," Catra said, walking into the spire.

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow followed, navigating the spire. So far, they hadn't seen anyone. She did notice a pattern; both the Crystal planet and Krytis were barren. Horde Prime had destroyed them in the past. Etheria was in grave danger. The galactic warlord would stop at nothing to ruin Etheria. Did he or his cronies chip more people? Did they abduct some individuals? Shaking her head, she paced forward. Why hadn't the group found the mysterious resident? Was the resident hiding from them?

Eventually, the group reached the end of a passageway. Entrapta wasn't using an outdated map, was she? She said she would guide them. Maybe this was a dead end, and they should turn around. Or retrace their steps.

Adora tapped her earpiece. "Entrapta, are you sure this is a door?"

"Yes. It's right in front of you," Entrapta said.

Adora pressed a hand against the wall. "It's a wall."

"Well, the schematics show a door right where you're standing. Data never lies."

Catra approached the wall. "Whatever, guys. Need a door?" She dug her claws into the barrier, then carved a hole in the wall and kicked out the cutout piece. "There's your door."

Bow frowned. "We don't know what we're dealing with here. Maybe you shouldn't smash stuff."

The group proceeded forward. From time to time, something invisible garnered Catra's attention. Did the magicat see the mysterious resident? Adora held Glimmer's hand as they strode through a hallway. Yellow spores materialized; Adora detected the open side of the spire, then stared at the stalagmites. Glimmer looked in the same direction.

"I have a weird feeling about this place," Glimmer said.

"According to Entrapta, there was someone here. Maybe they survived Horde Prime's invasion, but they were hiding," Adora said. "I hope we find them as soon as possible."

"Are you still thinking about Etheria?"

"Yeah. Are you?"

Glimmer nodded. "I'm sure we'll get there soon."

For Perfuma, meditation usually worked. So did drinking tea and trying to be positive. Right now? It felt as if everything was spinning out of control and crimping her harmony. The Best Friend Squad was still in space, some Rebels got chipped, and She-Ra didn't return. She paced back and forth in the tent, clutching her platinum locks. Would the Etherians lose their homes? The Princess Alliance needed to act at some point, but how would they do it without Adora and Glimmer? They were better at leading than the rest of the Princess Alliance was.

"Okay, Perfuma," Perfuma told herself as she halted by the tent flap. "Focus on the positives. Like, for the twelfth time today. Mermista, Frosta, Scorpia, and Castaspella didn't get chipped. Bow and Glimmer saved Adora. Catra's trying to be better. And..."

Shadow Weaver and Castaspella entered the tent, bickering. If there was someone Perfuma wanted to see, Shadow Weaver was at the bottom of the list. How was the witch still allowed to walk around freely? How much longer would the Rebellion be stuck with her? Frosta, Scorpia, and Mermista stepped forward. While Frosta and Mermista scowled at the sorceress, Scorpia furrowed her brows. Perfuma clasped her hands together.

"Surely this can't be everyone who's left?" Castaspella asked.

"They got Sea Hawk and many people in Salineas," Mermista said. "My kingdom is compromised."

Perfuma cleared her throat. "Spinnerella got mind-controlled, too. They could come back for us."

"What do you think we should do, hide?" Castaspella asked.

"Just until we figure out what to do. We could go to Mystacor," Perfuma replied. "It has an invisibility spell."

Shadow Weaver crossed her arms. "That won't work. Prime's controlling Micah and the other sorcerers. Mystacor is compromised."

Castaspella grimaced. "How did the Rebellion lose so many of our finest members, and yet we still have Shadow Weaver?" She glared at the old woman. "Why can't you depart from our sight?"

Shadow Weaver hissed. "I am helping you. If you want to get Micah back-"

"Don't talk to me about my brother." Castaspella glanced at the princesses. "We're wasting time here, and we must seek out the Horde. I lost my brother once, and I don't want to lose him again."

"We need to go somewhere safer," Perfuma said. "Before they find us and take more people away from us!"

Shadow Weaver rested a hand on Castaspella's shoulder. "Come with me. I know a way to help your brother."

Castaspella pushed Shadow Weaver's hand away. "I will never go anywhere with you. You're manipulative, dishonest, and desperate for power."

"You don't have a plan. I do."

"Fine. If you try anything, I won't hesitate to strike you down."

Perfuma watched as the two women left the tent. She turned to face the princesses. "I guess we better gather our things and go.

We'll just wait it out and hope that Adora, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow come home, despite the blockade."

Frosta conjured a pair of ice knuckles. "I'd rather fight the Horde!"

"I agree with Frosta," Mermista said. "We can't hide. We need to save our friends. I want Sea Hawk back."

Perfuma sighed. "We don't have a plan! I'm not saying it because Shadow Weaver said those words. I don't know what we can do. And if we try to fight, someone could get hurt. We could lose more people."

Scorpia nodded. "Perfuma has a point."

Adora and the others made their way to the spire's entrance. This place was confusing; it felt as if they explored a maze. Where was the person they were supposed to meet? A distant growl startled the group. Her fight-or-flight instinct kicked in as she widened her stance. Was there a creature lurking nearby?

"Did you guys hear it?" Bow asked.

Adora pressed a finger against her earpiece. "Entrapta, are we going in the right direction?"

"The energy signature is ahead of you," Entrapta said in a monotone voice. "Go through the door on your left."

"Door? W-what door?"

Everyone looked to the left. How did they not see the door before? Did they miss it when they entered the hallway?

"We're not going through that, are we?" Catra asked. "This place is weird."

"Entrapta said to go in there," Glimmer replied.

Everyone proceeded onto the path. Adora was sure she had a dream about this passageway at one point. Her thoughts drifted to memories of Etheria. She missed the smell of the forest, the cool breeze on a warm day, and the sensation of water splashing against her skin. Not to mention the wind in her billowing hair as she rode Swift Wind. It would be nice to attend another party and go to festivals. She had never forgotten the moment she tasted food outside the Horde for the first time. The ration bars had always been bland and unsatisfying. Catra's voice interrupted her thoughts, bringing her to reality.

"Seriously? How have you guys stayed alive this long?" Catra asked.

The path seemed to stretch, pushing the end further away. Adora gasped as she stared ahead. "We're not getting any closer, are we?"

Entrapta's voice pierced the earpiece. "Adora! Are you there? I gathered the records from Prime's occupation of Krytis. And guess what? This planet was once a First Ones colony. Horde Prime and the First Ones fought for control of Krytis, and he won. Something drove him away before he could conquer it."

"Entrapta, I'm sure it's new information, but are we on the right path?" Adora asked. "The door is getting farther away."

"Sorry, what door?"

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "What do you mean, what door? The one you told us to go through!"

"This is the first time we've talked since the last floor."

Catra's tail bristled. "I knew it! It was a terrible plan. Krytis is weird and unnatural! We need to get out of here before-"

"By the way, who's your new friend?"

Glimmer touched her earpiece. "What are you talking about? It's just the four of us."

"There's a definite heat signature, right behind you," Entrapta said.

The group whirled around; a humanoid figure idled in front of them, cocking its head. A blue mane enveloped its head and shoulders. The silhouette swayed, as if realizing it had been discovered. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow screamed as Catra tackled the creature. Within seconds, the magicat and the figure vanished. What was that? Adora had never seen anything like it. Inhaling deeply, she felt her heartbeat slowing down. Whatever that thing was, it must have been stalking the Best Friend Squad without alerting them. Screams and roars penetrated the air. Perhaps it was dangerous and should be left alone. It must have perceived them as a bunch of intruders.

"This is what scared Prime off?" Adora asked at last.

Glimmer walked ahead. "Who knows? Maybe it fought him and told him to fuck off."

Spores floated past the trio as they made their way to the entrance. Spikes emerged from the walls and floor, surrounding them. Adora gasped as one of the spikes shot toward her neck. Any closer, and they could impale her. She peeked at Bow and Glimmer, whose movements were also restricted. Everyone panted as they watched the spikes.

"Adora, what do we do?" Bow asked.

"I don't know. Nobody move!" Adora replied.

Glimmer scrutinized the spikes, then reached a hand out. They inched closer, forming smaller ones. Adora bit her bottom lip as she watched. They could hurt the queen.

"Glimmer, don't touch them!" Adora said.

"Hang on. I have to try something," Glimmer replied. She poked at a spike, making it evaporate into spores. "Illusions. These are all illusions. Then that means-" She traced a rune in the air. The spell shot out a wave, disintegrating the rest of the spikes.

"Oh, okay."

Glimmer chuckled. "I knew I was feeling something about this place. I assumed it was bad, but it's - it's not! It's magic."

Adora smiled, joining Glimmer in the laughter. For a moment, everything around the two women faded; the spores floated around Glimmer, making her seem ethereal. There was a gleam of happiness in the queen's eyes. Adora found it impossible to look away from those violet eyes. They had haunted her dreams ever since she befriended Glimmer. A roar drilled into her ears.

"We better check on Catra!" Glimmer said.

Glimmer teleported Adora and Bow to the ground below, appearing several feet away from Catra. The creature transformed into a calm feline, sitting politely. It emitted a soft sneeze. Shaking its mane, it purred. Why was it acting friendly? Was the creature trying to trick the group into a false sense of security? Catra stroked the feline's mane; it purred at the touch.

"Are you petting it?" Adora asked.

"I'm trying something here!" Catra spat as she shot up to her height.

"Catra, don't start!" Adora balled her hands into fists. "Don't you remember what I told you? I may sock you in case you decide to treat me and my friends like shit!"

The feline darkened from blue to red, growling at the group. Its tail and mane bristled. So did Catra's hair and tail. She said, "You made-" Her words halted, and she pressed her palms together. "Adora, I'm sorry for yelling at you." She released an audible exhale. "I'm working on my anger issues."

Adora's muscles relaxed a little, though not all the way. "I don't want you pulling any shit."

"This thing responds to emotions. I'll try to keep my anger under control." Catra faced the creature. "We won't hurt you. I do have a question. Why are you following us?"

The feline reverted to its calm exterior; Catra reached out a hand, allowing it to sniff. It pressed its head against her palm, then pulled away and began moving its mouth.

Catra's eyes widened. "Is it just me, or is this thing talking? Guys, tell me you can hear it talking."

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow shook their heads.

"It must have imprinted on you," Bow said. "It trusts you."

"Well, it shouldn't," Catra replied. She turned her attention back to the feline. "It says its name is Melog. It's been here by itself for a long time. Melog thought we were enemies, like the ones who came to steal magic. They dug into the ground, built machines."

Adora lifted her brows. "The First Ones."

"They took too much. And then... 'the one who destroys' came."

Melog shifted into a figure of Horde Prime; Adora flinched, her heartbeat speeding up. Why was she reacting like this? She wasn't in any danger, yet the illusion startled her.

She-Ra, return to me, or I'll destroy everything and everyone.

Adora cupped her palms over her ears. "Shut up!"

You still haven't turned into She-Ra without my help.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, hugging herself. "Get out of my head!"

"Adora, are you alright?" Glimmer asked as she pulled Adora into an embrace. "Focus on me, not the illusion. He's not here."

Adora's eyes fluttered open; she found herself gazing into Glimmer's violet eyes. "Sorry for freaking out."

"Don't apologize. I know it scared you, but you're safe with me," Glimmer said.

Catra cleared her throat. "Blondie, while you were busy freaking out, Melog told me what Horde Prime did. He tried to conquer Krytis, but couldn't. The magic was too wild for him. He couldn't defend against it. Now Melog is the last of its kind."

Glimmer released Adora. "So, magic is Horde Prime's weakness! How is Melog going to help, though?"

"I have an idea," Catra said, stroking her chin.

Home at Last

With Melog's help, Darla passed through the barricade, gliding into Etheria. As soon as the ship arrived in the Whispering Woods, the group emerged. Adora basked in the fresh air, inhaling the scent of patchouli and sandalwood. Bright sunlight warmed her skin; she took off her boots to feel the grass beneath her feet. The grass was as soft as she remembered, tickling her soles. A part of her wanted to run to a stream and splash in the water, but there were more important things to do, such as helping the Rebellion and saving the universe. She slipped the boots back onto her feet.

"Someone's happy to be home," Glimmer pointed out.

"I am," Adora said, smiling. "And we need to defend our home."

"We do. Let's find Perfuma and the others. They have to be somewhere around here, I think. Assuming there wasn't another raid."

They strode to an abandoned camp. Adora scrutinized the area, searching for signs of someone else's presence. They better not run into danger, as she still didn't have She-Ra. She hoped her alter ego would return before it was too late.

"Where is everyone?" Adora asked.

"They could be hiding," Bow said.

The bushes rustled; Glimmer jumped in front of Adora, stance widened as she summoned her staff. Bow nocked an arrow, and Catra seemed ready to lunge any second. Adora gawked at the bushes, anticipating an ambush. She didn't have a weapon on hand; without She-Ra's strength, a pair of bare fists wouldn't do much damage. At least she had some training in the Horde. Melog snarled, stepping forward. Netossa emerged, grunting as she clutched her wounded forearm.

"Welcome back," Netossa said. "What's Catra doing here? And what is this?" She pointed to Melog.

"I helped them save Adora," Catra said. "It's the least I could do after all the stuff I did to you guys in the past. Also, we found Melog on Krytis. It was the last of its kind."

"Oh. Weren't you the Force Captain who helped Hordak conquer Etheria?"

"Used to be."

Adora stepped past Glimmer. "Where's everyone? And what happened to you?"

Netossa glanced at the sky. "I couldn't get to my Spinny. I want her back. As for the others, they're in the new hideout."

"Where's the new hideout?"

"I can't reveal the location because a clone or a chipped person could be eavesdropping on us. Horde Prime once told us, through his hologram, that he hopes to capture Adora a second time."

Glimmer shook her head. "We won't let it happen."

"Anyways, Prime is forcing Micah, Spinnerella, and Sea Hawk to attack the people of Etheria. The Princesses are hiding, trying to figure out what to do next. But I can't wait for them."

Bow lowered his head. "We were gone. We weren't here to help our friends."

Tears stung Adora's eyes. "Horde Prime tore our home apart and took our friends. He won't stop until he's taken everything from us."

Glimmer sighed. "Netossa, I'm sorry. We should've been there. But we're here now, and we're not giving up. If I can rescue Adora from Horde Prime's clutches, we can save Spinnerella and

the others. Etheria needs us. We won't back down, regardless of what Prime throws at us. We'll show him that we're not done fighting yet." She extended a hand forward. "Anyone in?"

Adora rested a hand on Glimmer's. "We won't let Prime win."

"I'm in," Entrapta said.

Catra joined in. "Sure. Why not?"

Netossa smiled. "Thank you."

From time to time, Perfuma checked the exit. Castaspella hadn't returned, and neither did Shadow Weaver. What were they doing? Did Shadow Weaver try something funny? What if Castaspella got chipped? Perfuma strode to the strategy table, then sat. Piles of notes cluttered the map. Reports of disappearances and chipped individuals filled the papers. Earlier, Netossa had left the hideout to find Spinnerella. The dark-skinned woman had asked if anyone wanted to join her, but everyone said no. So far, the Princesses had remained safe by staying put. No reason to go out and fight the Galactic Horde. There was a risk of getting chipped or killed if they tried.

"Did Castaspella or Netossa return yet?" Scorpia asked as she occupied a chair.

"No," Perfuma said.

"Do you think about Bow sometimes?"

"Of course. You think about Catra?"

"Yes."

Mermista and Frosta joined the women at the table. The water princess leaned forward, propping her chin against her palm. Frosta crossed her arms, staring at the map. If Adora and Glimmer were here, they would come up with a plan.

"As annoying as Sea Hawk is, I miss him," Mermista said.

"I miss our friends," Frosta said.

Perfuma agreed with Frosta. She hadn't seen their friends for a while, and she wanted to know if they were safe. Her thoughts drifted to Bow. She had always liked him ever since they met. As she recalled them getting ready for Princess Prom, her heart fluttered. He had looked handsome in his formal outfit. Then again, he had always looked good. Maybe after the war, if the Rebellion won, they could hang out together. Or go on a date.

After the group battled with a chipped Spinnerella, they strode to a cave in the forest. Adora felt as though she didn't do much of anything during the fight. Didn't Madame Razz say the weapon was inside her? How would she activate it? She wanted to be She-Ra again.

"This is where the Rebellion is hiding out?" Glimmer asked.

"Yep. Why? Have you been here?" Netossa replied.

Bow smiled. "Oh, I can't wait to see every-"

Multiple vines trapped the group; Perfuma and the others emerged. "Show us your necks!"

"Perfuma, they're good," Netossa said.

"Your necks!"

Frosta checked the group's necks, then said, "They're clear."

Perfuma pulled Bow into a tight embrace. "Oh, Bow! Bow, it's really you!"

Frosta hugged Glimmer. "Ah, Glimmer!"

"Hi, Frosta!" Glimmer replied.

Swift Wind ran up to Adora. "You're back!" He nuzzled Adora.

Adora hugged the horse, then stroked him. "I missed you!"

Perfuma sobbed into Bow's chest; he caressed her back. "I don't wanna be in charge anymore!"

Adora and Glimmer walked into the hideout, holding hands. It felt so nice to be home, and to see one's friends after being held captive. A part of her feared it was a dream, or Horde Prime's illusion. She could wake up in the cell, awaiting rescue. What if the queen hadn't saved her? Would she have been forced to attack Etheria? She plopped onto a cot and buried her face in her hands. Images of the Velvet Glove surfaced; kneeling before Horde Prime, being touched without her consent, and attempting to fight him. She also thought of his chilling grin as he mentioned the "prototype." What kind of hero would let a creep control her mind?

"Adora, are you okay?" Glimmer asked, rubbing small circles on Adora's back.

"I failed at being the hero again," Adora said. "Earlier today, we tried to help Netossa save Spinnerella. I shouted 'For the Honor of Grayskull' out of instinct, only to not transform. You already know the rest. I tried to fight a clone, and another one grabbed me from behind."

"If I haven't intervened, they would have taken you."

Adora made eye contact. "I was going to break free."

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "I don't want to risk losing you again."

"I know. But it feels so hard without She-Ra."

Catra leaned against a crate, tail swishing from side to side as her ears caught snatches of conversations. Glimmer and Adora were

chatting, Bow and Perfuma sat together as he played the guitar, and Entrapta babbled about science. Catra was surprised that Shadow Weaver wasn't here. Some of the Rebels said that Weaver went somewhere with Castaspella. She resented the old witch anyways. What would she have been like if someone else instead of Shadow Weaver raised her? Would she have acted differently? Calmer? Happier?

Scorpia approached Catra. "Hey, Wildcat."

"Hey, you," Catra replied.

"What was it like to explore space?"

"Technicially, it was a mission. In space, you don't have a sense of time. Krytis and the Crystal planet are abandoned. Horde Prime destroyed them long before we arrived at both planets." As Catra spoke, Melog appeared by her legs. "We met Melog on Krytis. It turned us invisible so that we could go through the blockade."

Scorpia crouched, then reached for Melog's head. The feline nuzzled its head against her pincer. "It's so cute."

"And cool, too. It fought Horde Prime. Melog's story is also a little sad. It's the last of its kind. Now it isn't alone." Catra stroked Melog's mane. "We bonded as soon as we met."

"That sounds sweet. The bonding part, I mean. You said Melog doesn't have any family left, correct?"

"Yeah."

"Do you ever think about your own family and where you came from?"

Catra paused, repeating the question in her mind. She racked her brain for any possible memory of her real family. A vague image of meeting Adora surfaced. No one had explained how she winded up in the Horde as a little kid, other than conflicting stories of her origins. There could have been other magicats in Etheria. If she

had any parents and siblings, were they looking for her? Or did they forget about her?

"A few times," Catra said. "Mostly about who my biological parents could be and how they would have treated me."

"I figured you would wonder about your family, considering how Shadow Weaver treated you," Scorpia said.

"I bet Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio were also stolen from their families." Catra crossed her arms. "Hordak and Shadow Weaver must have assumed it was a good idea to kidnap little children and turn them into soldiers. Adora was born to power, so it was why Shadow Weaver favored her. The old witch never held any genuine love for us. We were afraid of Weaver, myself more so because she physically abused me."

"So, on a lighter note... I'm happy to see that you're changing. You're not as mean as you used to be." Scorpia wore a soft smile. "So, maybe after the war, we could, you know..." Her cheeks reddened. "Go on a date?"

She's so pure.

"We could," Catra said. "Assuming Horde Prime loses, and Etheria enters an era of peace."

Night surrounded the land. Glimmer and Adora reclined on their cot, intertwining their legs beneath the covers as they faced each other. She tucked a blonde strand behind Adora's ear. Not too many minutes ago, Adora untied her hair, allowing the sandy locks to flow loose. No matter what hairstyle the taller woman wore, she was cute. It was strange to think that Adora was once a Horde soldier. A lot had changed since the day Glimmer handed the sword to Adora in Thaymor. As She-Ra, the blonde brought a lot of hope to the Rebellion. Glimmer had never gotten over how majestic Adora looked in her She-Ra form.

Glimmer gazed at Adora's features; the slight curve at the tip of the blonde's nose. How soft Adora's lips looked. The way those blue eyes sparkled whenever Adora was happy. And the subtle dusting of freckles on her nose and cheeks.

Adora's fingers intertwined with Glimmer's. "Glim... I'm so grateful for you. I can't imagine being with anyone else."

Glimmer's cheeks heated within. "I feel the same way about you. You're a knight in shining armor."

"Because I wanted to be one for you. By the way, you saved me a few times, too."

"I guess it makes both of us knights."

Both women giggled at the comment. At the sound of Adora's laughter, Glimmer's heart skipped a beat. The pure joy in the blonde's voice warmed her heart. Adora emitted a snort as the laughter faded.

"You're adorable," Glimmer said.

"You too," Adora replied.

As time whizzed by, Glimmer grew tired. Heaviness seeped into her bones, and at first, she tried her best to keep her eyes open. The blonde's eyes, on the other hand, were closed. She peeked at the exit. Everyone else in the hideout was already asleep. Perhaps she should let herself sleep. After all, there didn't seem to be any danger lurking in the vicinity. Closing her eyes, she yawned. It didn't take long for her to drift to dreamland...

...

Glimmer heard a terrified scream as she explored a village. She broke into a run, searching for whoever could be in trouble. Dozens of clones and bots invaded the town; a large ship hovered in the sky. Was Horde Prime taking over the village? Another wail drilled into her ears; it sounded like a cry for help. She stumbled

into the square. What she saw elicited a gasp from her lips; a pair of clones had captured Adora. The blonde struggled to escape their grip. Before Glimmer could move, a beam of green light enveloped Adora.

"No! Don't take me back!" Adora shrieked.

"Adora, hold on! I'll stop them!" Glimmer shouted as she rushed toward the light.

Glimmer blinked, and the next thing she knew, she was in Horde Prime's ship. Adora wasn't here. Where did they take the blonde? If Prime chipped Adora again, he would regret it. Footsteps echoed off the walls; she whirled around. Adora glared at her, eyes glowing green. Horde Prime grabbed the blonde's wrist, his talons digging into her flesh.

"Your Majesty, you have failed She-Ra once," Horde Prime said.

"Let her go!" Glimmer shouted.

"You'll fail her again. How can you protect her from me if you're weak?" Horde Prime snickered. "I will take over Etheria, with or without She-Ra." He gripped Adora's neck and carried her to an abyss. "Say goodbye to your beacon of hope!"

"No! Don't hurt her! Please, you can't!" Glimmer begged.

...

Glimmer's eyes flung open; the first thing on her mind was Adora's safety. She rolled onto her back, limbs flailing as her mind struggled to catch up. The scene of Horde Prime carrying Adora to a chasm replayed as she hyperventilated. She had to stop him! As she scrambled to get up, something warm enveloped her wrist.

"Glimmer, breathe!" A familiar voice said.

Glimmer's gaze followed the sound and saw Adora staring back at her. Her hair clung to her cheeks from the sweat on her skin. As

she blinked, the rest of the room came into focus. They weren't on Prime's ship. The blonde wasn't in danger. Glimmer pulled Adora into a tight hug.

"Thank goodness you're okay!" Glimmer whispered.

"Are you okay? Did you have a nightmare?" Adora replied.

"Yes. I couldn't save you, and-"

"I'm still here. Nothing happened to me."

"I know, but the nightmare showed otherwise."

Adora sighed. "Nightmares are a pain, aren't they?"

"Yeah," Glimmer said.

Both women reclined; Adora stroked Glimmer's cheek. Soon, they fell asleep, holding on to each other.

To the Fright Zone

Adora stepped out of the hideout, stumbling into a grassy field. Millions of stars twinkled in the black sky; a golden silhouette materialized. It seemed so familiar; long flowing hair, a winged crown, and a billowing cape. She rushed toward the figure; they walked away before she could touch it. Where was She-Ra going? Why did the specter evade her? Without a second thought, she began racing, trying to catch up. She needed She-Ra's strength. As far as she knew, Etheria was in grave danger, and she had to do something.

"Please come back to me!" Adora shouted as she reached a portal.

The figure disappeared behind the portal. Adora descended to her knees, shaking her head. Was she not meant to be She-Ra anymore? Why didn't the specter answer her? What message were they trying to send her?

"Adora, look up," a feminine voice said.

Adora looked; a familiar brunette stood in front of her. "Mara? Why can't I turn into She-Ra? Didn't Razz say something about the weapon inside me? Things have gotten worse after I shattered the Sword of Protection."

"You can turn into She-Ra. Just unlock the power within you," Mara said.

"How do I do it?"

"Let it come to you."

"Let it come?" Adora tilted her head. "Are you saying I shouldn't try?"

"If you force it, you'll feel frustrated," Mara said.

Adora opened her mouth to respond, but Mara disappeared before she could speak.

...

Adora sat up. Most people in the hideout had already awakened to start the day. The Princesses gathered around the table, discussing plans. She recalled what Mara told her in the dream. According to the brunette, she shouldn't force it. Releasing an audible sigh, she swung her legs over the edge of the cot. She squeezed her eyes shut, then whispered: "For the Honor of Grayskull." Nothing came; no power boost and no transformation. At least she tried. Eyes fluttering open, she strode to the table and sat next to Glimmer.

"How did you sleep?" Glimmer asked.

"Fine. How about you?" Adora replied.

"Same."

Netossa rested her hands on the table. "There were reports that Spinnerella went to the Fright Zone."

Catra leaned against a collapsed walkway. "Isn't the Fright Zone abandoned? That place is a dump."

"I have no idea why she would go there."

Mermista yawned. "Anything on Sea Hawk?"

"He went to Salineas."

"I'd like to find him and take off the chip."

"And I'd like to get my Spinny back." Netossa opened a notebook. "I've been keeping track of everyone's weaknesses. And I've discerned the best tactical strategy to overpower our chipped friends. Spinny's weakness is obvious."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Uh-huh. Real obvious. And what is it, exactly?"

"Everyone knows Spinnerella twisted her ankle when she was a kid. If you keep her off balance, her injury will act up on her. Next time we fight, I'll target it, subdue her, and save her."

Bow glanced at his tablet. "Okay. Could we circle back to your not-at-all weird and detailed theories on our weaknesses?"

"Not all of us will be as easy as a twisted ankle," Glimmer said.

Netossa dropped the notebook onto the table. "Oh, you don't believe me. That's fine. I'll demonstrate. Entrapta's weakness; tech."

Entrapta smiled as she fiddled with her toolbox. "Well, I like technology and science."

Netossa began circling the table. "Mermista's? Fire. Frosta's? Same thing. Scorpia's? Clumsy and knocks things over. Adora can't act to save her life. Also, extreme hair-envy with She-Ra. Glimmer's? Self-doubt with overwhelming hubris."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "Whoa. It's personal compared to fire."

Perfuma grinned. "Oh, oh, do me! Do me next!"

"Fire," Netossa replied. "And an inability to unleash your full power due to your overwhelming fear of hurting the people you care about."

Perfuma clasped her hands together. "Some say it's a positive quality."

"It's not." Netossa turned her attention to Bow. "Bow's weakness..." She grabbed his weapon and snapped the string, then returned it to him.

Bow descended to his knees. "You've spent a lot of time thinking about this, huh?"

Netossa conjured a string to replace the broken one on the weapon. "Contingency plans are how you win, and I always win."

Catra stepped forward. "Okay, I get it. Don't you have anything on real threats, such as Horde Prime and his army?"

"What's his weakness?"

"Magic."

Adora shook her head. "I don't think we can stop him without She-Ra. But we can save our friends. We know where Spinnerella and Sea Hawk are. One's in the Fright Zone, and the other is in Salineas."

After the meeting, Glimmer teleported Adora and Netossa to the Fright Zone. Melog, Catra, and Perfuma had gone with Bow to visit his parents. The first thing Glimmer noticed about the headquarters was the lack of sound. Catra was right when she said the Fright Zone was abandoned. A visible layer of dust coated the floors and rubble.

"Something bad always happens whenever we're here," Adora whispered, holding up a sword. The sword wasn't the same as the She-Ra one, but it would do for now.

"We should probably stick together," Glimmer replied. "We can't lose anyone else."

Netossa paced ahead. "Can you guys keep it down? Stealth is important."

A gust of wind howled in their direction, blowing the debris across the hallway. The wind blew a second time, knocking the women off their feet. They forced themselves up; Spinnerella descended toward the ground, floating in midair.

"Still resisting Prime? What a shame," Spinnerella said.

"Spinny, this isn't you," Netossa said as she conjured a net. "Come back to me."

"No. Surrender to Horde Prime!"

Adora frowned. "Spinnerella, you have to fight the chip. Don't let Horde Prime control you."

"My fight is over. Lord Prime has given me peace. She-Ra, you must return to Horde Prime's light."

"No. I'm not betraying my friends. We're here to help you break free from Horde Prime's mind control."

Melog, Catra, Perfuma, and Bow made their way to the library, remaining invisible as they entered the building. The interior was dark; not a single light illuminated the area. Small, broken pieces of wood lingered on the marble floor. Something must have overturned a few tables. A single ladder had fallen to the floor. Perfuma scrutinized the doors and shelves. Did something happen to Bow's parents? She watched as Bow picked up a broken vase.

"I'll look around," Catra said.

"You don't know what could be lurking nearby," Perfuma replied. "We could run into clones or bots."

"What if Horde Prime has them?" Bow asked. "What if he chipped them?"

Perfuma rested a hand on Bow's shoulder. "We can't jump to conclusions. Perhaps they're somewhere safe."

"All of Etheria is under Prime's control. They can't defend themselves."

Perfuma detected a note on the table. "Bow, I think they wrote a letter for you. There's a chance they could be okay."

"They're dads. And now they've been taken by Horde Prime. I should've never learned archery. I should've never left home."

Catra appeared by the table, then picked up the note and showed it to him. "Bow, read this. While you guys were standing here, I checked the rooms for enemies. There isn't any lurking at the moment."

"What does it say?" Perfuma asked.

Bow grabbed the paper. "It says, 'what does the First Ones say when they burned dinner? It was ruined.'"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Some people aren't good at jokes."

"They're still my dads. Speaking of them, I know where they are."

"How can you figure out their location based on a bad joke?"

"It's a pun."

Catra rested a hand on her hip. "Same difference."

Adora and Glimmer stumbled into a dark chamber while Netossa fought a chipped Spinnerella. The steps to Hordak's throne lit up, revealing Horde Prime. Had he been tracking Adora? She maintained eye contact, clenching her fists to quell their shaking. An image of him looming over her as she kneeled by the green pool flooded her mind. He had caressed her cheek after she gasped for air. Even though he wasn't nearby, she could feel the phantom sensation of his icy palms brushing her skin.

"Ah, She-Ra," Horde Prime said.

"What are you doing here?" Adora asked.

"I came here to see what made Etheria so special, starting with my brother's amusing little stronghold. I have anticipated our reunion after the queen stole you."

"If you're hoping to control me again, forget it."

"But you haven't turned into She-Ra without my help." Horde Prime smirked. "Besides, my brother's research has given me everything I need to know. The technology of this planet is familiar to me. Ancient, crude, outdated. It will be child's play to bypass its defenses and take the weapon at its heart for myself."

"You will never get your hands on the Heart of Etheria," Adora said.

"Your fixation on saving the Etherians has made you weak. The power will be mine to take." Horde Prime began approaching Adora. "How much longer will you resist me, She-Ra?"

Glimmer stepped in front of Adora. "Why are you so obsessed with taking her back?"

"I can give her a purpose. She doesn't need the burden on her shoulders."

"Didn't you try to kill her? If you hurt her, I won't hesitate to end you!"

Horde Prime chuckled. "Your quest for power helped me find this planet. How are you doing as a queen? Still failing those you swear to protect?"

Adora scowled. "She's a great queen, and she's trying her best despite being thrown into the role after her mother's sacrifice. Glimmer is not a failure."

"I've heard enough. She-Ra, if you continue making people leave me, I'll destroy you." Horde Prime's fingers extended into tentacles. "See if you can strike me without the power you missed."

Adora moved past Glimmer and swung the sword at Horde Prime; the warlord caught the blade, tightened his grasp, and broke it in half.

"You're weak without your power," Horde Prime said. "I'll see if you can stop my plan without it. You most likely won't, because your resistance is futile. We'll meet again later."

Once Horde Prime left the chamber, Glimmer teleported Adora to Netossa. The dark-skinned woman trapped Spinnerella in a net and punched the chip. Spinnerella's eyes transitioned from sickly green to ocean blue.

"Spinny, you're my weakness," Netossa said, hugging an unconscious Spinnerella. "I'll never let you go."

"So, she's back," Glimmer said. "Let's take her to safety."

Glimmer teleported Adora, Netossa, and Spinnerella to the hideout. Then, Netossa carried Spinnerella to a cot and allowed her to recline. Adora's mind flashed to what Horde Prime told her. She hoped She-Ra would come to her as soon as possible, because his last four words sounded like a threat.

"Where are the others?" Adora asked, peeking at the exit.

Scorpia, Mermista, Entrapta, and Frosta approached Netossa.

"If you're talking about Bow, Perfuma, and Catra, I think they're still with Bow's dads," Mermista said.

"I'll take the chip off Spinnerella," Entrapta said.

Catra, Perfuma, Melog, and Bow made their way to the First Ones ruins. Bow's dads - George and Lance - greeted him with a hug. The couple mentioned finding something they thought could help everyone. The group walked to an area with crates and tents. Catra scrutinized lines and various shapes in the walls and ground. She thought of the time she and Adora saw simulations of their

past. Would she watch the scenes again? Would the group run into robot spiders?

"We unearthed an ancient secret, long forgotten," George said.

"You mean holograms, right?" Catra asked.

"A rebellion from the time of the First Ones, fighting against a powerful tyrant. Watch. Eternia."

A hologram materialized. "Greetings, administrator. What is your query?"

"Uh, that's cool, but my friends and I met her a while ago," Bow said. "She wasn't helpful."

Lance turned his attention to Bow. "We found something hidden in her programming."

Catra's tail swished from side to side. "Yeah, sure. While you're talking, everything is going to shit."

Perfuma held up a finger. "Catra, no negative vibes."

"Listen, Flower Crown. You care about Plumeria, right?"

"I do."

"What are you going to do if Horde Prime destroys Plumeria? Just stand there and let it happen?"

George cleared his throat. "For the honor of-"

Lance placed a hand onto George's shoulder. "Let me do it this time."

"You always get to do it."

"I don't. You did it last time."

Lance proceeded to say the signature line. A glowing blue orb appeared around the group; Catra stared at the shapes and symbols. It was cool. Was this what George and Lance found? How would it help everyone?

"We weren't sure what to think when we found this," George said. "We assumed it was a glitch."

"But then we remembered the message on your tracker pad and how it used coded language based on the star formations of the distant past," Lance said.

"Friend of-"

"Uh, not that one."

"I've got it. 'Mara.' There."

"Greetings, friends of Mara," the hologram said.

"Mara wasn't alone," Lance said. "She worked with a group of rebels going against their First Ones' leaders."

Catra crossed her arms. "Just like how the Rebellion fights the Horde, huh?"

"Of course."

The hologram spoke again. "There is one recording available. Would you like to review?"

"Play it," Lance said.

A new voice began speaking. "This is our last transmission. If anyone hears this, you need to listen. There's a Failsafe for the Heart of Etheria. It will allow you to destroy the Heart and end it for good. It's at the Arxia outpost. We lost touch with them a week ago. Mara bought us time, but it's too late for us."

The hologram vanished.

"A Failsafe," Bow said. "This could stop Prime from using the Heart."

"There's a problem. We don't know where Arxia is," Catra said.

"If the Failsafe is out there, we need to find it. We'll have to tell Adora." Bow's tablet rang, and he glanced at the screen. "Adora?"

"We got Spinnerella. By the way, how are your dads doing?" Adora replied.

"They're not chipped. I was worried they would be. There's a Failsafe for the Heart of Etheria."

Adora lifted her brows. "A Failsafe?"

"I'll tell you more once we get back."

To Seek out the Failsafe

Night came. Adora and her friends discussed the Failsafe. It was in Arxia, a location the map didn't show. The Failsafe could work; they could still save everyone. Shadow Weaver and Castaspella entered the hideout, garnering everyone's attention. Catra and Glimmer shot the old witch a death glare. Melog growled, moving toward Shadow Weaver. Adora wouldn't be surprised if they decided to attack the manipulative woman. However, no one advanced, despite Catra, Glimmer, and Melog vibrating their anger.

"We know where Arxia is," Shadow Weaver said.

"Where is that mysterious place?" Catra asked. "Also, what have you been up to?"

"While you were exploring space, some of us have been working to stop the Heart of Etheria from falling into Prime's hands. And we discovered the same thing you did. Rumors of a Failsafe. Arxia is another word for Mystacor, in case you're wondering."

Glimmer lowered her brows. "Are you kidding? After everything that has happened, you're still going after the Heart of Etheria? You saw the consequences. Horde Prime invaded our home, chipped a lot of people, and tried to turn Adora into a weapon for his army! And Casta, why are you helping this bitch?"

Castaspella frowned. "We're trying to free the magic for all of Etheria so that we'll be strong enough to fight Prime. I'm doing this for you and your father. Shadow Weaver is the lesser of two evils."

Catra patted Melog's head. "At least you admit she's evil."

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "You're one to talk, aren't you?"

Catra and Melog scowled. "We've already talked about how bitter you are."

Adora approached Shadow Weaver. "Tell us what you know about the Failsafe. What makes you think it's in Mystacor?"

"As any good sorcerer knows, Mystacor was built on the ruins of an ancient First Ones citadel," Shadow Weaver said. "Beneath Mystacor-"

Castaspella clapped her hands. "Ooh, can I tell this part?"

"Go ahead."

"Beneath Mystacor, there are many secret tunnels and rooms, forgotten and sealed off. No one has accessed them in centuries. There were whispers of what they contain."

"An artifact known as the Crystal of Arxia."

Castaspella pinched the bridge of her nose. "You said I could do it!"

Shadow Weaver sighed. "You were taking too long."

"Arxia. That must be the outpost Mara's friends mentioned," Bow said. "The Failsafe might be underneath Mystacor!"

"It won't be easy to reach it," Shadow Weaver replied. "But I spent my whole life studying the secrets of Mystacor. I can get us in."

Adora's brows drew together. "If you figured it out on your own, why come back here? Why do you need us at all?"

"Because Micah controls Mystacor. He's under Horde Prime's mind control. You allowed Prime to take too much ground, and you haven't summoned She-Ra. If he seizes the Heart, everything will be over. There's no time for half-measures, Adora." Shadow Weaver rested her palms on Adora's shoulders. "You must act now."

Adora brushed Shadow Weaver's hands off. "Guys, it's the only lead we have. It'll be a stealth mission. Catra, can you and Melog-"

Catra shook her head. "She's manipulating you!"

"As if you haven't done it to me before." Adora clenched her jaw. "I'll go get the Failsafe. Perhaps you should stay here while Melog accompanies us."

"You're right," Shadow Weaver said. "She will stay here. We can't let her slow us down."

Melog hissed. Catra pointed two fingers at her eyes, then at Shadow Weaver.

Glimmer teleported Adora, Melog, Castaspella, Bow, and Shadow Weaver to Mystacor's entrance. Melog turned the group invisible as they crossed the grounds and hid behind a rock. It was unusual to see Melog without Catra, but if the magicat didn't want to come, fine. Silence hung in the air as multiple sorcerers patrolled the area. A gray-haired woman with a staff peeked over her shoulder, eyes glowing green. The woman proceeded; Melog enveloped the group in an invisibility fog. They entered the fortress; indistinct voices murmured. A silhouette stood at the end of the hallway. Glimmer recognized him; it was Micah. Her father glared down the corridor, scowling. His eyes were as green as the gray-haired woman's.

Tears blurred Glimmer's vision. Adora caressed her arms; the blonde seemed prepared to say something, but no words came out. Micah stormed off. Shadow Weaver beckoned the group forward. Racing down the hallway, they approached a round purple room with a raised platform.

"Are we going in the-" Adora began.

Shadow Weaver slipped an arm around Adora's waist and cupped a hand over her mouth. "Keep your voice down!"

Adora broke free. "Don't grab me like that!" Her voice was a mix of anger and fear.

Glimmer was about to yell at Shadow Weaver when a sorceress emerged from the shadows, unleashing spells. The words could wait until after they returned to the hideout. She stepped forward and deflected multiple runes. Castaspella unleashed a rune, knocking out the sorceress.

"We have to hurry!" Shadow Weaver shouted as she grabbed Castaspella's arm.

They navigated the hallway, passing statues. Eventually, they approached a depiction of a sorcerer next to a figure.

"We're here. Follow my lead," Shadow Weaver said.

"Would a 'please' kill you?" Castaspella retorted.

Both women conjured a diamond-shaped spell and cast it at the wall. The rune gleamed over the image, bathing the area in a blue glow. As the wall vanished, the group hurried inside. Now in a dark hallway, they proceeded forward. Glimmer summoned a sparkling ball of light, then launched it upward. A variety of symbols covered the walls.

"Whoa," Glimmer said.

"They're cool, aren't they?" Adora replied.

"Yeah. Also, I don't trust Shadow Weaver. She could try something funny."

"It'll be okay. I need to get the Failsafe."

Shadow Weaver whirled around, glaring at the duo. "There's no time to waste. News of our presence will have reached the others by now."

Glimmer straightened her spine. "It was unnecessary to grab Adora from behind. If you hurt her-"

"Let's move on, girls."

A flash of anger flooded Glimmer's soul. She would love to punch that mask off Shadow Weaver's face. The group walked down the corridor. At one point, Bow touched the wall, inspecting the depictions.

"What is all of this?" Bow asked.

"We're on the right path. The Crystal of Arxia is the key to reaching deep magic within Etheria," Castaspella said. "Many have tried and failed to find it. Those who hungered for more power sought other ways to obtain the magic... with disastrous results."

"The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake," Shadow Weaver said. "Why do you keep bringing it up?"

"You roped my brother into your twisted dark magic when he was a child. You could've killed him!"

"It would've worked had he not broken the connection. Micah was an exceptional sorcerer, even then. It's a shame it didn't run in the family."

"Entrapta, you can't go out there just because you realized something about those chips," Catra said, standing in front of the exit.

"They would fuse to their victims' nervous systems!" Entrapta replied, holding up a tablet. "We could run out of time if I don't cut off Prime's connection to the chips."

Catra bit back some of the harsher words that formed in her mind. If Entrapta ran off into danger, the geeky princess could get chipped. Someone could run after her and get caught. Prime's minions would discover the hideout as a result. Shadow Weaver

leading a few people into peril was bad enough. She couldn't begin to imagine the chaos that would ensue if dozens of clones and bots raided the place.

"I need to find a place with a high concentration of clones," Entrapta said.

"Are you serious?" Catra asked. "Don't you realize how unsafe it would be to go to an area with hundreds of clones?"

"I'm still doing it."

"I don't have Melog at the moment, so... I guess we'll take Swift Wind." Catra led Entrapta outside and beckoned Swift Wind closer. "Entrapta wants to go somewhere real quick. Can you take us to a place filled with clones?"

"It's not a good idea," Swift Wind said.

"I agree. But Entrapta won't take no for an answer," Catra replied.

"Hop on. I can get you there fast, and I'll bring you back if you run into trouble."

Catra and Entrapta mounted Swift Wind. The alicorn glided into the air, carrying them across the sky. She kept a close eye on her surroundings, anticipating an ambush at any moment. Several minutes dragged on; they arrived in an area not too far from a Horde camp. The women hopped off Swift Wind and strode to the bushes. Catra peered through the greenery. A structure caught her attention; it was white, green, and black.

"What is going on over there?" Swift Wind asked.

"I don't know, but it doesn't look good," Catra said.

"The pattern is complex. I need more connections," Entrapta said.

Swift Wind unfurled his wings and blocked Entrapta. "No way! No tech is worth Prime capturing you!"

"This isn't about tech. It's about our chipped friends. If I can get it to work, I can save them."

"Catra and I will cover you from behind. Please be careful."

The group entered a room. As Adora stepped forward, she heard Shadow Weaver telling her to wait. The next thing she knew, a wall of fire surrounded her. This trap would kill her. She would never get to the Failsafe, she would never save Etheria, and-

"Adora!" Glimmer shouted as she teleported to Adora's side. She grabbed her and teleported a second time; they reappeared in front of the group.

Adora made eye contact. "I'm okay." A smile tugged at the corners of her lips. "Did you just jump into the fire for me?"

Glimmer grinned. "Of course I did."

"You're cute when you protect me."

"You're cute when you do that, too." Glimmer approached the fire and reached out to touch it. "It's an illusion?"

"Some of the fire is illusory, and some is real. Be careful," Shadow Weaver said.

Castaspella led the way through the flames; the others followed, and Adora stayed behind. She thought of Mara's message in the dream. What if she had lost She-Ra's power forever? What if it wasn't temporary? Could it be permanent?

"I see you're still struggling to summon She-Ra," Shadow Weaver said. "You and Glimmer are close again. Do you think it's wise? She activated the Heart of Etheria."

"It's none of your business," Adora said.

"It is. Your emotions are blocking the power. When will you transform again?"

"I don't know. Mara appeared in my dream and told me to let She-Ra come to me."

"She-Ra is a being of pure magic. To unleash her full strength, you must be focused and clearheaded. You are letting your emotions pull you into too many directions. Glimmer distracts and confuses you. If you care about her, focus on protecting her. Don't rely on her to save you. I didn't raise you to be someone who needs rescuing. The world needs you as She-Ra, not Adora. If She-Ra can't stop Prime, then we are all doomed."

"I will stop Prime, no matter what," Adora said as she moved past Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver's words replayed in Adora's mind as she walked. She desired She-Ra's strength. The problem was that she couldn't turn on the power. Horde Prime had somehow tapped into it after chipping her. It would be a mistake to rely on someone to rescue her whenever she was in trouble. Of course, there were times when her friends protected her. Back then, she had the Sword of Protection, meaning she could transform anytime. She didn't have to wait for someone to save her. Her captivity in the Horde was one time, although she somehow escaped those handcuffs.

"Adora, are you alright?" Glimmer asked as she caught up to Adora.

"I'm good," Adora replied. "I must figure out this She-Ra thing on my own."

"Did you let Shadow Weaver get into your head?"

"I need to focus. I can't afford to be a damsel in distress."

Catra swore she heard a male voice speaking to Entrapta. A small part of her wondered if it was Hordak, because of the way the

speaker growled. She stepped through the greenery, ignoring the sensation of thorns poking her skin. The sound led her to a boulder, where Entrapta stood. A clone glowered at Catra as she snatched Entrapta's wrist. For a moment, the clone's eyes darkened from green to red. So, it was Hordak.

"Catra, what are you doing?" Hordak asked.

"Hordak, I knew you would remember me," Entrapta said, grinning.

"Go. Maybe then, these imperfections will leave me."

"Your imperfections are beautiful!"

Catra yanked Entrapta to Swift Wind's side. She didn't care if Hordak remembered Entrapta; they had to get out of there. If the other clones had seen Entrapta, they would come running. And they would take her away. The Rebellion couldn't afford to lose anyone else. Catra climbed onto Swift Wind's back. So did Entrapta. The horse ascended into the sky, moving as quickly as possible.

"I wish he would come with us," Entrapta said.

"Why do you say that?" Catra asked. She hadn't forgotten those times when Hordak asphyxiated her with a device.

"I like him."

"I get it, but he can be brutal."

"There's some good in him."

"Whatever."

As they chatted, Swift Wind arrived at the hideout's entrance. Catra and Entrapta walked inside. Her gaze flitted around the room. Adora and the others hadn't gotten home yet. Catra strode to a crate and sat. A few people had already fallen asleep.

Scorpia, however, remained awake. The scorpioni woman sat next to her.

"So, how was your short trip?" Scorpia asked.

"Risky," Catra said. "Entrapta insisted on putting herself in danger just to figure out a way to cut off Prime's connection to the chips. And she ran into Hordak."

"Did he say anything?"

"They talked. It was brief, as I didn't want us to get ambushed."

"I'm glad you guys are safe."

Catra nodded. "Anyways, it's gonna be midnight soon. I'll keep watch."

Not Letting Mara's Sacrifice Be in Vain

"That is the Failsafe?" Glimmer asked as the group reached a giant crystal structure.

"It's bigger than I thought it would be," Bow said. "How are we gonna get that to the Heart?"

Shadow Weaver strode to the crystal. "The Failsafe is a code, stored inside the crystal."

"So, what do we-" Adora began.

Shadow Weaver pushed Adora toward the crystal. "It needs a password." She pressed Adora's hand onto the structure. "I think you already know what it is."

"We're friends of Mara," Adora said.

A bright blue light radiated up the crystal; it cracked open, breaking into three sections. A triangular light connected them. Symbols dotted the crystals. Glimmer still felt suspicious; she didn't want Shadow Weaver to hurt Adora. She glowered at the witch, watching her every move. So far, Weaver didn't do much, other than talk to the group. She observed the symbols.

"What does it say?" Glimmer asked.

"Someone needs to go inside and accept the Failsafe? What does that mean?" Adora said.

Shadow Weaver gripped Adora's shoulders. "It means the Failsafe must be bonded to a willing soul and carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in order to be deployed."

"And we're sure that's safe?" Bow asked.

"We can't turn back now. The Failsafe is within our grasp."

Adora glanced up, then strode forward as a light crackled over the crystals. Glimmer rushed to the blonde's side and grabbed her wrists. There was no way she would let Adora suffer. Who knew what could happen? Was Shadow Weaver tricking Adora into taking her own life? Shadow Weaver could've taken the Failsafe for herself. But she didn't. What was stopping the old sorceress? Glimmer whirled around and shot the woman a death glare.

"You were here before, right? You could have gotten the power, and you didn't. What are you not telling us?" Glimmer spat.

"You're being paranoid," Shadow Weaver replied. "This is the only way to stop Prime. Adora understands that well enough."

"What will happen to her?" Glimmer balled her hands into fists, summoning purple orbs. "Tell us right now."

Castaspella narrowed her eyes. "Answer the question."

Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers. "Whoever uses the Failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed. That much raw magical power would burn any mere mortal apart. None of us are strong enough."

"But She-Ra is," Adora said.

"Only She-Ra can hope to survive the process. No one else can do it."

Adora moved closer to the crystal. "And if I don't survive it?"

"Then the magic will be restored to Etheria through your sacrifice. You will give us the power to bring us victory. Prime will be defeated. Your friends will be free."

Castaspella grimaced. "You were planning this all along!"

Glimmer scowled. "Shadow Weaver, this will not work."

"There's no way we're risking Adora!" Bow said.

Adora cleared her throat. "Stop it! I'll take the Failsafe, regardless of what anyone says."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's forearm with both hands. "No, don't! Shadow Weaver is going to hurt you. And the Failsafe could end your life! Don't you see the risks?"

Adora frowned. "Even if she is, it's better than Prime getting the Heart and destroying the universe! We're out of options." She pulled her forearm out of Glimmer's grasp. "It's the only way."

"No, you won't. Starlight-" The sound of whispering voices cut off Glimmer's response. She turned around and gasped. "Dad?"

Two sorcerers accompanied Micah. He unleashed a spell; Glimmer summoned a magical shield, deflecting the rune. Smoky ropes wrapped around Adora, restraining her arms. Bow fired arrows at the sorcerers. A blast of dark magic hit Shadow Weaver in the face.

"Dad!" Glimmer said.

Micah held his hands behind his back. "Hello, daughter. I'm so pleased to see you." He glanced at Castaspella. "And you, sister." He glowered at Shadow Weaver. "Her, not so much."

Glimmer launched a spell at Micah; he repelled her magic with dark energy. He blasted at her; she teleported, and this time, the tendrils wrapped around her leg, preventing her from rising off the floor. Adora shouted her name, then said: "For the Honor of Grayskull!" Bow, Melog, and Castaspella continued battling Micah and the sorcerers. Glimmer peeked at Adora; the blonde dashed into the crystal.

"Adora, no!" Glimmer shouted.

The light beamed down; tendrils of glowing energy materialized on the steps, snaking their way to Adora. A pained scream erupted from the blonde's throat as the magic lifted her off the ground. A bright flash pierced the air, nearly blinding Glimmer.

Before she could do anything, Micah cast a spell that seeped into the floor. It trapped Castaspella, Bow, and Shadow Weaver.

"Is that-" Glimmer began.

Micah chuckled. "Dark magic. After all, I learned from the best."

Castaspella gasped. "Micah, no!"

Micah lifted Castaspella into the air. Black shadows slithered over the crystals, obscuring Adora from view. Glimmer couldn't take her eyes off the crystals. What was going to happen to her love?

"Adora! Are you okay? Tell me you're okay!" Glimmer shouted.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!"

A white light flooded the room, washing away the dark energy. Adora emerged from the light; her She-Ra form was different. A long, blonde ponytail flowed out behind her. The white and gold uniform accentuated her legs and torso. A pair of wings appeared on She-Ra's crown and boots. Her cape was split in half, like Glimmer's. A slender blade rested in her hand; its cross-guard formed a crescent moon shape. Within seconds, Adora knocked down Micah and the sorcerers.

"I got the Failsafe," Adora said, walking toward Glimmer. "Let's get out of here."

A symbol glowed on Adora's chest; she extended a hand to Glimmer. Now the blonde was carrying the Failsafe in her body. Would she survive? Or would she end up dying in the end?

Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand, then rose. "You took the Failsafe, didn't you?"

"I have no other choice," Adora said. "If I die when saving Etheria-"

"Adora, don't start." Glimmer led Adora into the hallway as the others stood. "I was sure there was a way for you to save everyone without throwing your life away."

Once Adora and her friends returned to the hideout, the others noticed the symbol on her chest and asked questions. She gave them the same answer each time. Catra was the only one who didn't speak; the magicat leaned against a crate the entire time, glowering. Was Catra mad at her, or at Shadow Weaver? Maybe it was a little bit of both. Adora didn't care what Catra thought of the Failsafe. Nothing would stop her from saving everyone. She approached the mirror; once again, she was in her normal form. Ignoring a dull pain in her chest, she took off her outfit and slipped into her pajamas. Glimmer hadn't said anything ever since they got back. Had Adora worded her response the wrong way? Was Glimmer expecting a different answer?

Adora knew Glimmer had a tendency to worry about her. And this was no exception. At least she would be a proper hero for Glimmer and the rest of Etheria. Plopping onto the cot, she heard footsteps approach.

"Adora, how are you feeling?" Glimmer asked as she sat next to Adora.

"I'm fine," Adora replied.

"Are you sure? When you took the Failsafe, you screamed in pain. Does it hurt in any way?"

"A little. But it's worth the sacrifice."

"Worth the sacrifice?"

"Yes."

Glimmer wrapped her arms around Adora's neck. "Before tomorrow comes, I want to share something with you. Close your eyes."

Adora closed her eyes. She became aware of the shorter woman's proximity as their breaths mingled. Then, Glimmer's lips met hers in a passionate kiss. Her pulse skipped a beat. Was this how first kisses felt? Soft and loving? She snaked her arms around Glimmer's waist, inhaling the scent of lavender. A minute later, she pulled away, her eyes fluttering open. She gazed into Glimmer's eyes.

"Glim..." Adora breathed out, unsure what to say.

"Yep. We shared our first kiss," Glimmer said. "Adora, I love you. And I don't want to lose you."

Catra stepped toward the duo. "Not to interrupt your moment, but I still can't get over you following along to Shadow Weaver's plan."

Glimmer glanced at Catra. "Taking the Failsafe has been Adora's decision. We may not trust Shadow Weaver, but we're trying to save Etheria."

"It's true that we don't trust Weaver." Catra's ears flickered. "She hurt us a lot. The old hag deserves to be punished. Perhaps she could be locked away or something."

"You'll face consequences, too. If we win the war, I'll think of a punishment for you and Shadow Weaver."

"And what about Hordak?"

Adora crossed her arms. "He won't get off scot-free, either. Catra, helping the Rebellion isn't going to erase your past. I gave you a lot of chances to leave the Horde."

Catra sighed. "I know. And we may not be as close as we used to be. Also, Sparkles?"

Glimmer arched her brows. "What is it?"

"Take care of Adora."

The magicat strode to the exit, beckoning Melog to her side.

"Where are you going?" Adora asked.

"I may go on a long trip," Catra said.

Within seconds, Catra and Melog were gone. She had made her choice again. If she wanted to go on a trip, so be it. Adora and Glimmer reclined on the cot. The queen traced her finger along the glowing lines on Adora's chest.

"So, we'll go tomorrow, right? To take the Failsafe to the Heart?" Glimmer whispered.

"Yeah," Adora said. "And I'm going to defeat Prime, too."

"What if... you don't survive the Heart? What if Horde Prime kills you?"

Adora hesitated for a moment. "I... I don't know. I won't let Mara's sacrifice be in vain."

Glimmer ran her fingers through Adora's hair. "I want us to be together for a long time."

"Me, too. But I'm She-Ra, and I'm meant to be a hero."

"Can you talk about what you truly want? Don't you have a dream?"

"My dreams don't matter." Adora closed her eyes, exhaustion blanketing her body. "Mara was young when she crashed her ship."

"Starlight, you're talking like this again."

Adora's eyes flung open. "Like what?"

"You're saying that you will throw your life away." Glimmer's eyes shone with tears. "I didn't rescue you only to lose you again!"

Adora rolled to her side. "I know you feel that way. It'll be okay in the end. Etheria's safety matters more than my own life. Goodnight."

Once again, Adora squeezed her eyes shut. She felt Glimmer's arms wrap around her from behind. The queen's breath tickled her neck. Quiet sobs wafted into her ears. After an hour, she drifted to dreamland...

...

Adora was standing in a white space, with nothing to see. White transitioned to green; a silhouette materialized, looming over her. She recognized the creepy eyes and evil smile. He placed an icy palm onto her face, then moved it to her chin. Eventually, his palm made its way to her neck. A word lodged itself in her throat. Did he see the Failsafe on her chest?

"You are being difficult, She-Ra. Your power is back. Since you'll use it against me and my army, I'll continue my plan," Horde Prime said.

"I'll stop you," Adora replied.

"I will dispose of you. Then, I'll cleanse all of Etheria."

Sinister laughter drilled into Adora's ears as Horde Prime gripped her neck, tightening his hold. The air escaped her lungs as she struggled to breathe. Her pulse raced as she grabbed Horde Prime's wrists.

...

Adora gasped as her eyes flung open. The image of Prime choking her lingered as she fought to control her breathing. Did Horde Prime know what she did? Either his chipped victims informed him, or he dug through their memories.

"Adora, you're not dying, are you?" A tired voice murmured.

Adora rolled to her other side, facing Glimmer. "No, I'm not. I saw Horde Prime in the nightmare again."

"Ugh. Prime is the worst."

"He is."

"You know, I couldn't stop thinking about what could happen to you."

"Is it why you're not sleeping?"

"Yes. I was watching you the whole time, thinking you would take your last breath any minute."

"I'll remain alive. I'm not dying. Can you sleep?"

Glimmer sniffled. "What about if morning comes?"

Adora caressed Glimmer's cheek. "I'll be fine."

Morning came; Glimmer sat up, then looked at Adora. So far, the blonde was still breathing, despite what she saw in a nightmare. In the nightmare, she had woken up to find Adora dead. The Princesses had gathered around the cot, staring at the blonde's body. And Horde Prime had appeared in the hideout, taking pleasure in Adora's death. Thankfully, though, none of that happened. She swung her legs over the edge of the cot and strode to the table. Everyone else had already sat down for the meeting.

It didn't take long for Adora to join them; she was now in her She-Ra form. "Prime is getting closer every day to figuring out how to access the Heart of Etheria. If he succeeds, he can use it to destroy worlds, galaxies, maybe even the entire universe. The Failsafe is our only chance at stopping him. He still has our friends. His hold grows stronger the longer they're chipped. If we don't free them now, we'll lose them forever. Prime holds every

advantage in this fight. He'll be ready for us. But we have a plan. Entrapta?"

"I succeeded in cracking Prime's signal pattern. If I access his Spire network, I can use it to broadcast a jamming frequency that will disable all the chips in Etheria, freeing everyone at once," Entrapta said.

"I need you all to get Entrapta to the Spire and keep Prime's forces distracted. She will jam the signal. I'm gonna take the Failsafe to the Heart and destroy it, once and for all. We're going to make sure that Prime can never hurt anyone again. We're ending this for good."

Love to the Heart

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow entered the Crystal Castle. An automated voice spoke disjointedly. The group approached the platform. A hologram glitched, emitting blue lights in various places. Adora was ready to carry the Failsafe to the Heart. She held Glimmer's hand; the two women made eye contact. Glimmer wore a soft smile.

"Let's get this done with," Adora said.

"Yeah," Glimmer replied.

The automated voice spoke again. "Warning. Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time."

"We're friends of Mara," Adora said. "Now show us where the Heart of Etheria is."

The hologram scanned Adora and stopped at the symbol on her chest. "Welcome, friends of Mara."

An opening materialized behind the hologram. The trio began navigating a hallway. Adora ran her hand along the wall, scrutinizing the symbols. She glanced at Glimmer, then forward. The nightmare from last night surfaced. What if Prime was waiting to trap her? His threat replayed in her mind. Shaking her head, she reminded herself to be strong and not let him intimidate her. She paced ahead, chewing her bottom lip as she walked. Her She-Ra form began glitching. What was happening? Was She-Ra leaving her again?

"Are you scared?" Glimmer asked as she caught up to Adora.

"No. I hope it works," Adora replied.

Bow smiled. "It's okay, Adora. We'll be with you the whole way. When we get back, it'll be a whole new world."

Adora heard someone laughing in the distance; she followed the sound to a room and found herself looking at a Glimmer with the old hairstyle. The room changed to a courtyard at Bright Moon Castle. Glimmer held up a staff, smirking as she widened her stance. Adora recognized the memory; both women had sparred whenever they weren't on missions. After the queen took the throne, there wasn't as much time to practice fighting together. The scene transitioned to a ballroom; the Glimmer with the asymmetrical bob strode closer and reached out a hand. Instead of the dress Glimmer wore to Princess Prom, she had a long, sparkling gown that brushed the floor.

Adora took Glimmer's hand; the queen and the room disappeared. She stared into the blackness, wondering what just happened. It would be nice to dance with Glimmer, as they didn't get a proper one at Princess Prom. Footsteps approached, and she whirled around.

"You're going the wrong way," Bow said. "The trail is back there. Are you okay?"

"We need to be careful," Adora replied. "We can't let this place distract us." She moved past Glimmer and Bow.

The trio continued navigating the Crystal Castle. Adora's form flickered again. Eventually, the temple projected memories of her time on the ship. It included her nightmares and what she did while chipped. Her mind drifted to the conversation she and Glimmer shared last night. A memory of their first kiss flashed into her mind. Would it also be their last kiss? If she died, at least she would die when saving Etheria.

Adora found herself standing in a forest. This place seemed familiar. Glimmer and Bow came into view. The queen wore a concerned expression as she stepped closer. Adora stared at the sword; a heap of vines snaked around the blade. She pressed a hand to her chest, covering the symbol. Why couldn't she focus? Etheria was running out of time. The planet needed her to be a

hero. As Shadow Weaver said, the world needed her as She-Ra, not Adora.

"Adora, are you okay?" Bow asked.

"What's going on?" Glimmer asked.

Adora approached the sword. "I think I know. Also, I'm doing this."

"How do we get out?" Bow replied.

"When I broke the sword, I thought I could make my own destiny. But I can't. It will always end like this."

Glimmer furrowed her brows. "What do you mean, 'end?' Adora, I don't want to lose you. You mean something to me. I mean, you're everything to me." Tears streamed down her cheeks. "Starlight-"

"Glitter-bug, I'm losing She-Ra. I'm distracted, confused, and scared. I can't be any of those things if this is going to work. When I'm gone..." Adora's voice trailed off. "Anyways, I need to go the rest of the way by myself."

"No, you're not. I want us to have a future together!"

Tears stung Adora's eyes. "I love you guys so much. I could never have done any of this without you. Glimmer, when I'm gone, I'll be watching over you. Thank you for everything."

Glimmer stepped closer. "Adora, no!"

For Glimmer, everything was a blur. Adora grabbed the sword; a bright light flashed, forcing her to shut her eyes. Despite anticipating a scream, all she heard was silence. The forest transformed into the Crystal Castle. The blonde was most likely alone, searching for the Heart of Etheria. Descending to her knees, hot tears dripped to the floor. If only she didn't activate the

Heart, Adora wouldn't have to take the Failsafe. The ground began rumbling; multiple symbols on the wall glowed green.

"Adora! Where are you?" Glimmer shouted as she rose.

There was no response. Was Adora too far away to hear Glimmer? And why did every surface in here turn green?

"Guess we'll have to look for Adora," Glimmer said. "She hasn't responded. There has to be a reason why."

A purple circle gleamed on the floor; Shadow Weaver, Melog, and Catra appeared. Didn't Catra say she was going on a trip? What changed her mind? Why was she here? Was something going on? Had Catra seen something out there? The magicat gripped Glimmer's shoulders, nails poking into her skin.

"What is this for?" Glimmer asked. "I thought you were going on a trip."

"Not anymore. Where's Adora?" Catra replied.

"She went to the Heart on her own."

The ground rumbled again. Bow said, "Catra, what's going on?"

"Horde Prime is hacking the planet," Catra said. "All of this is from him!"

"He's gonna take the Heart."

"That's not all. Prime captured Entrapta."

"If Prime has Entrapta, that means Sea Hawk, Micah, and the others are still chipped. We have to get back up there."

Glimmer shook her head. "We can't leave Adora! I'll find her. Bow, you go with Catra. Help the others."

Catra and Bow approached Melog. The feline circled around them, and they vanished.

Adora's eyes fluttered open; what she saw took her breath away. A large river curved toward the horizon, surrounded by mountains and greenery. Pinks, blues, and other colors filled the sky. So did planets and stars. As the light shimmered, a woman stood beside her. It was Mara, wearing a She-Ra uniform. She was sure the river and the former She-Ra were illusions. Any moment now, she could blink and wind up in a trap.

"I'm going to save Etheria, no matter what it takes. I won't let your sacrifice be in vain," Adora said. "I promise."

"But at what cost? I never wanted to die. I sacrificed myself so you would never have to. Why are you doing this, Adora?" Mara replied.

"It's better this way. My friends will be safe. They'll be happy."

"And you? What do you want when all of this is over?"

"It doesn't matter. I'm She-Ra. It's what I'm supposed to do."

Mara took Adora's hands. "You're worth more than what you can give to other people. You deserve love, too. Adora, you're so close. Don't give up yet."

Tears welled in Adora's eyes as she listened to Mara's words. Green lines materialized, eliciting a gasp from her lips. "Mara? What's-" The entire scenery turned green.

Horde Prime appeared. "Ah, She-Ra. So this is where you've run to hide." He made his way to the two She-Ras. "How strange. I must have fought her. Must have known her face. However, I have no memory of it."

A creature shrieked, drawing Adora's attention to the trees. Where was it? She couldn't see it. Would it pounce on her? She tightened her grip on the sword, bracing herself for an attack.

Adora glowered at Horde Prime. "You're not here. You can't stop me."

"I've seen so many like her over the years. One by one, all their faces have been lost to oblivion. Just as yours will be," Horde Prime said.

A claw slashed Adora's side, forcing her to lose She-Ra. Clutching her side, she descended to her knees. "I will stop you."

"Now you can't," Horde Prime replied, stepping in front of Adora and holding his arms behind his back. "A parting gift from the First Ones; their old security system. Capable of taking out even one as strong as She-Ra. You will never make it to the Heart, Adora. Your own people made sure of that. Goodbye, my oldest enemy." He vanished.

A tentacle beast reared up, opening its mouth. Getting distracted had resulted in this. How would Adora succeed? Pain flooded her body as she peeked at the green wound in her side. Sweat poured down her forehead. She fixated her eyes on the monster. If she didn't lose She-Ra, she would have defended herself. A cloud of sparkles materialized; Glimmer stood between her and the creature, holding a staff. The queen's wings unfurled to full length.

"Adora, you're lucky I can teleport to your rescue," Glimmer said. "I'm getting you out of here."

"Glimmer! You can't be here. It's too dangerous," Adora replied.

"I won't leave you to die in here. We'll go to the Heart together!" Glimmer teleported, then reappeared above the monster. "Starlight! Get to the door!"

Adora rose to her height, her legs shaking as she attempted to maintain her balance. It didn't take long for her legs to give out beneath her weight; she leaned against the wall, panting. Glimmer unleashed kinetic blasts at the tentacle beast, dodged its attacks, and launched multiple runes. Adora held up her hand,

willing herself to transform into She-Ra. Pain flooded her forearm; a tentacle wrapped around her leg, lifting her into the air.

"Let her go!" Glimmer shouted as she shot a spell at the tentacle.

The tentacle released Adora; she began falling. Before her body could meet the ground, Glimmer caught her and carried her through the doorway. The queen whirled around and unleashed a fire spell at the monster. Within seconds, the beast died.

"You're safe now," Glimmer said. "And we better hurry."

They raced through the hallway; not once did they pause. Eventually, they reached a chamber. The Heart crackled and gleamed with magical energy. Three yellow streaks snaked around it.

"The Heart of Etheria," Adora said. "We made it." She strode toward the Heart. "For the Honor of Grayskull." Once again, pain shot through her arm. Screaming in agony, she fell backward into Glimmer's arms.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer asked, holding Adora up.

"I can't transform," Adora said as she watched the room turn green. "It's Prime's virus. It's keeping me from becoming She-Ra."

"Can the Failsafe work without her?"

"Yes. Get as far away as you can. I have to do this next part on my own."

Glimmer grabbed Adora's hands. "Adora, is something going to happen to you?"

Adora nodded. "Without She-Ra, the magic will destroy me. I'm sorry, Glim. I'm so sorry." Her shoulders shook with sobs. "There's no more time. It has to end here. I can still save everybody." She caressed Glimmer's cheek. "It's okay. I'm ready."

"I'm staying. We're doing this together."

Adora clutched her chest; she collapsed to the floor. Glimmer sat, cradling her head in her lap. All Adora could do was gaze into Glimmer's eyes. A bolt of green light struck the Heart.

"I'm sorry," Adora whispered.

"Stay awake!" Glimmer replied.

Adora shut her eyes, slipping into unconsciousness...

...

Adora's eyes fluttered open; she detected her reflection in a waterfall. A tiara rested on her head, reminiscent of Glimmer's, but with a red gem in the front. A raindrop earring dangled from her ear. Her hair cascaded to the middle of her back. Instead of a jacket and pants, she wore a white floor-length gown with gold accents. The neckline stopped just above her chest. A door creaked open, and she gasped. Turning around, she saw Glimmer standing in front of the door. The queen wore a sparkling lavender dress with a long blue cape. Her hair was shorter, with an undercut.

"I was wondering what took you so long, Starlight. Are you ready to head over to Plumeria to meet Bow's and Perfuma's little one?" Glimmer said.

Adora nodded. Glimmer held out a hand. She reached for Glimmer's hand; the queen glitched like a hologram, then disappeared. Horde Prime materialized, smirking.

"A beautiful wish. But there will be no future. Not for you," Horde Prime said.

The room transformed into a green void; a pair of restraints enveloped Adora. She struggled, tears floating upward as she sobbed. The area glitched; she looked up to see an opening in the ceiling. Glimmer leaned into the room, crying.

"Adora, please come back. Stay. We need you here!" Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand. Their fingers intertwined. "I need you here. Adora..."

...

Adora's eyes opened. The Heart flashed with green lightning; Glimmer conjured a magical shield, protecting both women from the bolts.

"I'm here," Adora said.

Glimmer held Adora closer, their breaths mingling as the queen leaned in. Warmth blossomed in Adora's chest as their mouths brushed together, the queen's lips impossibly soft against her own. A glow enveloped the women in rainbow colors. Adora could feel her hair levitating; within seconds, she transformed into She-Ra.

Peace

Chapter Notes

> As I was finishing up the rewrite, I thought about how quickly Horde Prime was defeated, and how short the ending was.
>
> Adora's search for her family had been forgotten ever since Season 3. She deserves some closure.
>
> Don't get me started on Glimbow. Like, come on. Let Glimmer and Bow remain friends.

Adora and Glimmer made their way outside; she plunged her sword into the ground, healing the planet. Then, she shot a light beam at Horde Prime's ship, destroying the vessel. They approached Horde Prime; the warlord glowered at the women as he released Entrapta's pigtails. The Failsafe had worked. Adora hoped everyone on Etheria had gotten free from Prime's mind control. She pointed the tip of her sword at him. Glimmer summoned a staff. Horde Prime's hair tubes extended into tentacles.

"Any last words before we defeat you?" Adora asked.

"Insolent brats," Horde Prime spat. "I was about to take the superweapon. She-Ra, I thought I executed you. Your friends managed to wrest many people from my Light."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "Etheria is not yours to take. She-Ra and I will not let you hurt people anymore. You will pay for your crimes; kidnapping Adora, using her as a weapon, and chipping people. One more thing - you tried to kill Adora using the tentacle beast!"

Horde Prime launched his hair tubes at Adora; she blocked them with her sword. His fingers transformed into tentacles; he unleashed them at Adora's throat and began squeezing the air out of her lungs. Glimmer shot a kinetic blast at his tentacles, forcing

him to release the blonde. The queen teleported, then reappeared behind him; she clapped her hands together, expelling a purple beam at his back. Prime fell forward; Adora attempted to stab him, but he rolled away before she could deliver a blow. He rose to his full height, staring down the duo.

"I will destroy you, She-Ra. I will dash the hopes of the Rebellion," Horde Prime said. "Your Majesty, you have been as formidable as the warrior. What will you do if I rid the world of her?"

Glimmer pointed her staff at Horde Prime. "Don't even consider it. As long as I live, I won't let any harm come to Adora and those I care about."

Adora lowered her brows. "Prime, you're not going to win."

Horde Prime chuckled. "You will fail. The ones you swore to protect will suffer. You are pathetic. Why do those pesky Etherians see you as the hero? Their beacon of hope? How often will you turn on them, either under the influence of data disks or chips? You have even failed the queen."

Adora closed the distance between herself and Horde Prime, then jabbed her sword at his chest. The blade met his chest, forming a gash. Green blood seeped from his wound. She attempted to land a strike; Horde Prime evaded the sword, moving as fast as possible. Glimmer unleashed a barrage of spells at him; Prime dodged each one. A large beam collided into his abdomen, shoving him across the ground. He fell onto his back.

"Getting tired?" Glimmer mocked.

Horde Prime forced himself up. "It will take a lot more to defeat me. Though all is reduced to rubble, I shall rise again. So it has been, and so it always shall be."

Adora strode toward the warlord, holding up her sword. "No! You are wrong. Dead wrong!" She slashed his abdomen, then his side.

"Did you not hear what I told you?" Horde Prime launched every tentacle at Adora, pinning her to the ground and knocking the sword out of her hand. "You will perish!"

The metal ends of the tentacles bit into Adora's skin. Straining, she reached for her sword and missed. A feral yell pierced the air; Glimmer appeared above Prime and swung her foot at his jaw. He staggered, his tentacles retreating as he fought to maintain his balance. Adora retrieved her weapon, lunged at the warlord, and sliced his hair tubes.

"Fuck!" Horde Prime spat as he whirled around and blocked the sword with his tentacles. "You are delaying the inevitable!"

Glimmer rammed her palms together, emitting a bright flash at Horde Prime and blinding him. Adora charged at him and plunged the blade into his side. Green blood emerged, staining the sword. The queen teleported to them and stabbed Prime's chest with her staff.

"You lost," Adora said.

Horde Prime laughed. "You amuse me, She-Ra. I haven't died."

A golden glow enveloped Adora's sword. Glimmer's staff gleamed purple. Gold and purple raced along their weapons, then entered Prime's body. He had no time to react; a flash encased him, and within seconds, he vanished. There was no trace of his presence; not even ashes remained. Both women stared at the empty spot, where Prime once stood. Adora reverted to her normal form. It was over. No longer would Etherians fear for their lives.

"We did it, Glitter-bug. We won in the end," Adora said.

"I know," Glimmer replied.

Holding hands, they made their way to where their friends stood. Both women lifted their free fists into the air; everyone cheered. Bow pulled Perfuma into a side hug. Scorpia picked Catra up, embracing her. Sea Hawk and Mermista shared a quick kiss.

Entrapta joined them, head hanging low. The geeky princess should be happy like the rest of them.

"Entrapta, is something wrong?" Adora asked as she approached Entrapta.

"Hordak's gone," Entrapta said. "He fought Horde Prime and died."

"Well, he was a brutal dictator. But I wonder why Hordak would turn against Horde Prime."

"He tried to protect me."

Catra walked over to Adora. "You and Sparkles did it."

Glimmer appeared by Adora's side. "Catra, you will help Etherians rebuild for five years. And then, you can go on a trip and take Scorpia with you."

Catra nodded. "I'll be okay with that. Are Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, Double Trouble, and Scorpia joining me in the rebuilding process?"

"Yes."

Bow ran toward the women. "Adora! Glimmer! You guys were awesome!"

Adora smiled. "I know."

That night, there was a huge celebration in Bright Moon. Bonfires burned, fireworks exploded in the sky, and people sang songs and danced. The victorious Rebels celebrated, happy that their fight was over. No longer would they lose anyone else. No longer would they lose their homes. Bow and Perfuma shared their first kiss. Sea Hawk sang shanties, while Mermista reluctantly listened as she drank. Netossa and Spinnerella danced together. Catra and Scorpia cuddled as they leaned against a tree. Everything seemed perfect; it was the beginning of peace.

Glimmer walked over to Adora; the blonde had been sitting on a bench, gazing at the stars. She sat next to Adora, then rested a hand over hers. Adora made eye contact. Despite the smile, there seemed to be another emotion in the taller woman's eyes. Had Adora been deep in thought? If it was the case, what could her love be thinking about? For a moment, she recalled Adora talking about finding her real family. When it came to parental figures, Shadow Weaver was a horrible guardian to Adora and Catra.

"Aren't you happy?" Glimmer asked.

"I'm glad the war is over. But there's something I never had the chance to do," Adora replied. "I wanted to find my real family. Not that mine on Etheria isn't enough."

"So... does it mean another space adventure?"

"Perhaps. First, I want to take a break."

"Makes sense, considering." Glimmer drew Adora into an embrace. "You went through a lot."

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's shoulder. "All of us did. When I passed out at the Heart, I had a vision of us. It seemed to take place in the future."

"A vision of our future selves?"

"Yes. Both of us looked beautiful. You have this cute undercut hairstyle, and my hair got a little longer."

Glimmer imagined Adora with longer hair. Also, the word "beautiful" stood out to her. "What did we wear in the vision?"

"I had on a white dress with gold accents. You were in a sparkling lavender dress."

"Wow."

"Also, you were talking about seeing Bow's and Perfuma's child."

Glimmer wrapped an arm around Adora's waist. "Did we have a kid, too?"

"I didn't see any in the vision," Adora said.

"Oh."

"I'm sure it's a little early to talk about kids, but I don't think I could be a good parent. What if I repeated Shadow Weaver's abusive parenting?"

"I doubt you would. You're sweet and compassionate."

As they continued talking, the moon rose higher into the sky. Eventually, Adora closed her eyes and yawned. Glimmer glanced at the blonde. Was Adora falling asleep? She caressed Adora's cheek; the blonde's eyes fluttered open.

"Getting sleepy?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora whispered.

"Let's go home, then."

Adora was walking through a hallway in Bright Moon Castle, footsteps echoing. As she made her way to a door, she pulled its handle and stepped through. The next thing she knew, she found herself standing in a cell on Horde Prime's ship. Chilly air seeped into her jacket as she stared at the green barrier. The room transitioned to a familiar platform with a throne. She was fighting Glimmer and Catra.

Adora blinked; she winded up in a room with the tentacle beast. The monster roared, approaching her. Its tentacles grabbed her leg, levitated her upward, and drew her toward its mouth. She struggled to break free. All she could think about was her coming demise. She attempted to turn into She-Ra; the power didn't come to her. Everything went black; sinister laughter echoed in

her ears as green light flooded her vision. The sea of green transformed into Horde Prime's eyes.

"Adora, wake up!"

...

Adora jolted awake, trembling. Images from the nightmare melted away as she became aware of Glimmer's hands resting on her shoulders. She was in the queen's room. Horde Prime was no more. It was just a nightmare. Regardless of what she told herself, her pulse refused to slow down. She melted into Glimmer's embrace. The queen rubbed small circles on her back, whispering into her ear.

"You're safe here," Glimmer said. "Breathe."

Adora inhaled shakily, then exhaled. Within minutes, her heartbeat slowed down, as did her breathing. Pulling away, she peeked at the window. It could be three in the morning. Although it was too early to be awake, she didn't want to return to dreamland. The nightmare could be waiting for her.

"I heard you whimpering in your sleep. Nightmare?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah," Adora replied.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"To be honest, not really." Adora shuddered, recalling a scene from the nightmare. "I... I don't want this to be a dream, and wake up back on *his* ship. I don't want to awaken to us quarreling all the time."

"I know what you mean. I don't want it either. To be fighting. And watching Horde Prime control you."

"I'd rather not hear his name."

"Sorry."

"It's fine. It's just that..." Adora's voice trailed off. She would be bringing up the mind control and unwelcome touches again. "The memories are still fresh. Being chipped, and allowing him to touch me without my consent."

Glimmer tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. "He's not here. We defeated him, didn't we? If you want, I could take you to a healer. You could go alone, or we'll have a session together. And remember the Steam Grotto in Mystacor?" Her palm settled on Adora's cheek.

Adora placed a hand over Glimmer's, leaning into the warm touch. "Yeah, I remember the Steam Grotto."

"We could relax together in the hot, steaming water again."

"That would be nice."

"So, do you want to go to a healer?"

"Mind if I answer tomorrow?"

"No."

Glimmer gave Adora a quick kiss on the lips. "Let's get back to sleep. We need it."

Both women reclined, cuddling. Adora couldn't ignore how warm the queen was, how much she radiated an aura of comfort, and how reassuring Glimmer's caresses were after a nightmare. And... the queen's soft humming? It was like a lullaby. Her eyes fluttered shut, the tendrils of sleep pulling her closer to dreamland.

The following day, Catra, Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, Double Trouble, and Scorpia were tried for their crimes. Glimmer told a few guards to watch them in case they tried anything while helping Etherians rebuild. However, there were reports of Shadow Weaver going on

a reconnaissance. Adora and Catra parted ways, not as enemies or friends, but as acquaintances. Although everyone in Etheria tried to adjust to the newfound peace, they feared another war. They lost so much over the years; homes, friends, families, even lives. When afternoon came, Glimmer took a break from her royal duties to spend time with Adora in the courtyard.

Adora looked different; she wore a white and gold t-shirt and a pair of light blue pants. She still sported boots. Her hair cascaded to her shoulders. A ray of sunlight illuminated her blonde locks, creating a subtle halo.

"Have you decided if you wanted to go to a healer or not?" Glimmer asked as she held Adora's hands. They stood by the rose bushes, staring into each other's eyes.

"I may go," Adora said.

"When do you want to start?"

"Soon."

Glimmer's gaze flitted to Adora's outfit. "So, new look?"

"Yes. I was getting tired of the old one," Adora said. "It reminded me too much of everything that had happened."

"I figured it would. The combination of white, gold, and blue looks nice on you."

Adora's cheeks flushed, highlighting her freckles. "Thanks."

Glimmer tapped Adora's nose. "You're cute when you blush."

As the months whizzed by, Adora and Glimmer booked sessions with a healer. Their nightmares came less often, and they learned to overcome their triggers. Still, there were times when it felt as if they took a few steps back in their healing process, especially if one of them had a panic attack. Soon, another year passed, and

they became accustomed to the era of peace. There might have been occasional uprisings in isolated parts of Etheria, but they were quickly dealt with. One morning, Adora and Glimmer made their way to Mara's ship. Micah offered to watch over Bright Moon for a while.

"Ready to find your family?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said, fingers intertwining with Glimmer's as they boarded the ship.

They walked to the cockpit; Adora sat in the captain's chair. "Darla, set course for Krytis."

Within minutes, the ship took to the sky, gliding through the atmosphere. Adora was finally going to find her family. Would they recognize her? Did she have any siblings? It didn't take long for Mara's ship to fly into space. It had been a while since they were out here. Last time they were here, they had visited several planets after leaving the Velvet Glove.

"What would you say to your family?" Glimmer asked, interrupting Adora's thoughts.

"I'm not sure," Adora said.

"I'll be there with you." Glimmer rested a hand on Adora's shoulder. "When my dad and I reunited after he was stuck on Beast Island for years, we weren't sure what to say at first, either."

"You weren't a baby back then when you lost him."

"Still, I was little. I remember my mother crying for days because she thought he died. Anyways, if I can talk to my dad, you can talk to your parents."

Adora nodded. "It's just that I don't want to say the wrong thing."

Glimmer smiled. "You'll be fine."

Her True Family

Darla arrived in Eternia, a planet with advanced tech. Adora and Glimmer made their way into a city. She gazed at the structures. Entrapta would be obsessed with all the tech in this place. A person in armor approached them.

"What brings you to the City of Eternos?" The armored person asked.

"We came here to search for my family," Adora said.

"Where are you from? And what are your names?"

"We came from Etheria. A portal took me to that planet when I was a baby. My name's Adora, and this is Glimmer."

"Adora, you bear some resemblance to Prince Adam."

Adora tilted her head. Resemblance? Was she related to royalty? The lost princess who was stolen from Eternia? More questions followed, flashing through her mind. What would her life be like if she grew up on Eternia instead? Would she be unaware of the war on Etheria? Glimmer squeezed her hand, drawing her attention to the queen's violet eyes. Then, Adora glanced at the person in front of them.

"Can we go see Prince Adam?" Adora asked at last.

"He's out at the moment, but King Randor and Queen Marlena are in the palace. Follow me," the stranger replied.

Both women began following them through the city, navigating its streets. The skyscrapers reminded Adora of First Ones tech. A few skiffs glided across the sky. She looked ahead. A palace towered over the city. Its walls had an orange hue, and the structure was circular. The tower roofs resembled domes. Snatches of conversations and music filled the air. A scent of baked goods wafted into Adora's nose. Her stomach growled; she hadn't eaten

anything for a while. Soon, she and Glimmer approached the palace entrance. A pair of guards pulled the large doors open, revealing its interior.

The duo stepped inside; what Adora saw took her breath away. A painting depicted a king and queen standing together, and a blonde man sitting on a chair. She moved toward the portrait, then squinted her eyes at the blonde man's features. His face resembled hers, although he had a sharper jawline. Also, his eyes were a darker shade of blue. Could this be her family?

"They were right," Glimmer pointed out as she appeared by Adora's side. "You look a bit like him. Maybe you're related."

"Yeah, maybe," Adora said. "Other than the portal, Light Hope never told me about my biological family."

Adora and Glimmer proceeded through a hallway, passing doors and arches. The decorations and rug had a somewhat dated appearance. Eventually, the duo made their way to a throne room. A man and a woman stood in front of the thrones. The man had dark blonde hair, while the woman's hair was reddish-brown.

"I'm Adora. This is Glimmer," Adora said. "I came to Eternia to look for my family."

"We have a daughter named Adora," the woman replied. "When she was a baby, a portal stole her."

"A portal took me to Etheria."

"So, you're our Adora?" The man asked.

Adora nodded. "I think so. When is Prince Adam gonna be back home?"

"Soon."

An hour later, Adora, Glimmer, and the royal couple entered the dining hall, then occupied empty seats. Servants arranged food around the table. A blonde man joined the royal couple. He wore a pink vest over a white long-sleeved shirt, and he had broad shoulders. This must be Adam.

"Hello," Adora said.

"Hi. What are your names?" Adam replied.

"Adora and Glimmer. We're from Etheria, a planet we grew up on. Well, Glimmer was born on Etheria. I wasn't."

Marlena cleared her throat. "A portal stole her when she was a baby. Adora, tell us about yourself."

Adora sighed. "Okay. I grew up in the Horde. A woman, Shadow Weaver, raised me and Catra. The Horde's propaganda taught us to hate princesses and the Rebellion. One night, when Catra and I took a skiff, I fell into the bushes and had a vision of the Sword of Protection. Light Hope told me that I'm destined to be She-Ra. I snuck out again and ran into Glimmer and Bow. At first, we fought over the sword, and at one point, we ran into a monster. I turned into She-Ra to distract it. Later on, in the morning, Catra came to me in Thaymor, and I told her I can't go back. She got mad over my choice to join the Rebellion."

"I've heard stories of She-Ra. There was a previous one, long before any of us were here," Marlena said.

"I know who you were talking about. Anyways, Glimmer teleported me away before Catra could take me back to the Horde. Ever since I saved Thaymor, we had many more adventures. I gave Catra several chances to leave, and she said no each time. One time, she tried to destroy Etheria with a portal. Afterward, Glimmer and I started fighting. She didn't have the time to process her grief after her mother sacrificed herself in the portal. The weight of her royal responisibilities didn't help matters. And Double Trouble, disguised as Flutterina, got in the way of our

relationship. One fateful day, Glimmer activated the Heart of Etheria, resulting in me breaking the Sword of Protection and Horde Prime kidnapping me."

"There had been stories of a space army invading planets and destroying them. Before you and Adam were born, some of the strongest sorcerers and warriors hid Eternia so there wouldn't be an invasion."

"Like Etheria being hidden in Despondos?"

"I think Mara did it for a different reason."

"Oh. I'll continue the story from the moment I got beamed onto Prime's ship. He asked me to betray my friends, and when I refused, he told his clones to 'purify' me." Adora shuddered at the memory as she spoke. "What happened next, it was awful... they chipped me... and threw me into a green pool..." She squeezed her eyes shut. The trauma shouldn't be bothering her. Yet it did.

A warm hand enveloped Adora's, and her eyes opened. She smiled at Glimmer.

"Do those memories still make you uncomfortable?" Glimmer asked.

"A little," Adora said.

"It takes time."

Adora glanced at the king and queen. "Horde Prime controlled my mind and touched me without my consent. Eventually, Glimmer arrived and fought my chipped self. Horde Prime tried to kill me, but she was quick to save me. We explored a few planets and returned to Etheria to help our friends. When I took the Failsafe, I turned into She-Ra without the Sword of Protection. I carried it to the Heart. Glimmer revived me with her words. She told me that she needed me, and I woke up. We defeated Horde Prime together."

"She sounds fiercely protective of you," Adam said.

"She is," Adora replied. "One time, Glimmer saved me from being mind-wiped by Shadow Weaver."

Randor smiled. "Glimmer, thank you for keeping our daughter safe."

Glimmer returned the grin. "I'd do anything for Adora."

Adora pulled Glimmer into a side hug. "I can't imagine my life without Glimmer. She's the best thing that has ever happened to me."

Adam sipped his drink. "So, if you two are getting married in the future, maybe you could invite us."

"Adam, we live on different planets." Adora turned her attention to her parents. "I'm so happy to have met you guys. I will visit anytime I want. My true home is on Etheria."

Marlena placed her fork onto her plate. "You are welcome to visit us whenever you want. Your father and I are glad to see you after years of being apart. I must admit, I still feel a little sad that I didn't get to see you grow up into a wonderful young woman."

Adam held up a finger. "Adora, you told us you turn into She-Ra sometimes, right? I have an alter ego, too. He-Man. I defend Eternia from our foes. Skeletor, Keldor, and others. My girlfriend, Teela, accompanies me on my journeys. She can be quite protective."

Adora chuckled. "Reminds me of Glimmer."

"It seems to be a thing for powerful heroes to have partners who jump to their defense."

"Yeah."

After spending time in Eternia, Adora gave her family farewell hugs before she and Glimmer went home on Mara's ship. She said that it was like coming to the end of a long journey. They told their friends about their trip to Eternia, and how it felt for her to meet her biological family for the first time. Soon, Bow and Perfuma announced that they were getting married. Sea Hawk and Mermista got engaged, too. One day, Adora and Glimmer went out on a date by the Whispering Woods. They were having a picnic during the warm afternoon.

Adora opened the jars of lemonade; one for her, and one for Glimmer. The queen set two plates of dumplings on the picnic rug. Berries dotted the plates. A soft breeze rippled through Adora's hair. She couldn't keep her eyes off Glimmer. Prior to their date, her girlfriend had a haircut. It was the same style as the one she saw in her vision of the future.

"You really like my new hairstyle, don't you?" Glimmer asked, blushing.

"Of course I do," Adora replied.

"I thought you would."

Adora brought a dumpling to her mouth and took off a bite. It was soft and chewy. A combination of flavors lingered on her tongue; spicy and sweet. She picked up her jar and sipped the cold, refreshing drink.

"Is it good?" Glimmer asked.

"It's delicious," Adora replied.

"It's a different version of the dumplings I made on Mara's ship on our way to Eternia."

"Oh."

"Dad helped out a little. Although I had to tell him not to put bugs in it."

"He still eats bugs?" Adora snorted. "He really did get a taste for them after surviving Beast Island."

Glimmer chuckled. "He did."

The two women finished their meals. Adora thought of the question that would change their relationship. Digging through her pocket for the ring, she replayed the words in her head. How would Glimmer respond? Would the queen accept? Pulling out the ring, she revealed it to her girlfriend. Glimmer scrutinized the diamond. It glittered in the sunlight; small purple gems surrounded the diamond.

"Glim, ever since we met, I've been in love with you. You're the best girlfriend I could ever ask for, and I'm so glad you came into my life. Well, I kind of came into yours. Or, we stumbled upon each other by accident," Adora said.

You sure have a way with words, don't you?

"Okay? Are you-" Glimmer replied.

"Yes, I am. Will you marry me?" Adora asked.

Tears brimmed in Glimmer's eyes. "Yes, Starlight. I will!"

Adora slid the ring onto Glimmer's finger. "I love you, Glitter-bug."

"I love you, too."

On the day of their wedding, Adora checked herself several times in the mirror. She wore a long white gown with fingerless gloves; a tiara and a veil rested on her head. Her hair was pulled back in a braid. Since her brother and his girlfriend were staying in Etheria for several days, they arrived at the castle to watch the ceremony. The door creaked open behind her, revealing Adam. He would accompany her down the aisle.

"You're not nervous, are you?" Adam asked.

"I'm fine. It's just, you know, I don't want to mess it up," Adora replied, wringing her hands.

"You look great. And I'm sure you'll be okay. Ready to walk?"

"Thanks for the encouragement." Adora walked over to Adam's side. "I'm ready."

The twins made their way to the courtyard, where the Princesses and the others sat. On the other end of the aisle, the queen waited for Adora. Glimmer wore a sparkling kimono dress with a lavender sash. The sight of the shorter woman took her breath away. Piano music swelled as Adam escorted Adora toward the arch. Hints of other instruments mingled with the tune. By the time Adora reached Glimmer, she let go of Adam's arm and took Glimmer's hands.

"We are here today to witness the marriage of Adora and Queen Glimmer. Adora, will you promise to take care of my daughter for as long as you live?" Micah said.

"I will," Adora said.

"Glimmer, will you stay by Adora's side for as long as you live?"

"I will," Glimmer said.

"You may now kiss."

Adora and Glimmer leaned in; their mouths met in a passionate kiss. Cheers erupted from the crowd; several people tossed confetti into the air. This was where she was meant to be; together with Glimmer, for the rest of her life. There was no place she would rather be. She had never thought she would get a happy ending. But she did. This was her happily ever after. And it was what she truly wanted.

Adora pulled away; both women joined arms and strode past the guests. They entered the castle and made their way to the ballroom. Eventually, everyone took seats at their assigned tables.

A multi-layered cake idled on a banquet table, waiting for the newlyweds to take their first slice.

Before the dance, Adora and Glimmer approached the cake. Everyone gathered nearby. She grabbed a knife and cut a small piece onto a plate. The two wives retrieved forks and sunk them into the slice. Then, they fed each other.

"To us," Adora said as she grabbed a wine glass.

Glimmer picked up her own glass and clinked it against Adora's. "To us. As queens, we will watch over Etheria together."

Now it was time to dance. They walked to the center of the ballroom, wrapped their arms around each other, and began swaying to the music. Adora and Glimmer stared into each other's eyes. At times, one of them would lower the other into a dip. They added twirls and other moves.

For many years, the two queens ruled together, defending Etheria and making sure there were no wars.

The End

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